



CITY: Pg 3

CM Gupta felicitates UPSC qualifiers



NATION: Pg 4

Rainfall at several places in north, fog returns in Delhi



FILM: Pg 12

‘Cinema of heart & sensibility taking a beating in theatres’

OVER 20 NATIONS TO IRAN: CEASE ATTACKS, REOPEN HORMUZ

Iran’s N-plant hit, no leak

Trump’s mixed signals: Hints at wind-down, adds troops

ASSOCIATED PRESS

DUBAI: As the war in the Middle East enters its 4th week, it appears to be heading to a dangerous phase with Iran’s Natanz nuclear enrichment facility being hit in an airstrike Saturday, an official Iranian news agency reported.

It said there was no radiation leakage, as Israeli defence minister warned of an upcoming surge in attacks on Iran.

Israel Katz, the defence minister, said in a video statement that next week, “the intensity of the attacks” by Israel and the United States against Iran’s ruling theocracy will “increase significantly”.

He spoke shortly after fragments from an Iranian missile slammed into an empty kindergarten near Tel Aviv.

Overnight and into the morning, Tehran saw heavy airstrikes. In Iraq, a drone struck the intelligence service headquarters in Baghdad, killing an officer.

US President Donald Trump said on Friday he was considering “winding down” military operations in the Mideast even as the United States was sending three more amphibious assault ships and roughly 2,500 additional Marines to the region.

Trump’s post on social media followed an Iranian threat to attack recreational and tourist sites worldwide.

The mixed messages from the US came after another climb in oil prices plunged the US stock market, and was followed by a Trump administration announcement it was lifting sanctions on Iranian oil already loaded on ships, a move aimed at wrangling soaring fuel prices.

Britain meanwhile condemned “Iran’s reckless attacks” after its military fired missiles at the UK-US air base on the island of Diego Garcia in the Indian Ocean on Friday.



View of a kindergarten hit by fragments of an Iranian missile in Rishon LeZion, Israel, on Saturday AP/PTI

INTO WEEK 4

» In Iraq, a drone struck the intelligence service headquarters in Baghdad, killing an officer

» Britain meanwhile condemned ‘Iran’s reckless attacks’ after its military fired missiles at the UK-US air base on the island of Diego Garcia in the Indian Ocean on Friday

» Britain has not participated in US-Israeli attacks on Iran, but has allowed American bombers to use UK bases to attack Iran’s missile sites

» We are getting very close to meeting our objectives as we consider winding down our great Military efforts in the Middle East: Trump

cia in the Indian Ocean on Friday. UK officials have not given details of the attempted strike, which was unsuccessful. It’s unclear how close the missiles came to the base, which is about 4,000 kilometres from Iran. Continued on P4

US unanchors Iran oil

MPOST BUREAU

WASHINGTON: The United States has announced the temporary lifting of sanctions on the sale of Iranian oil stranded at sea in an effort to cool down soaring global crude prices.

US Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent said the temporary measure will make available 140 million barrels of Iranian oil to global markets.

“This temporary, short-term authorisation is strictly limited to oil that is already in transit and does not allow new purchases or

production,” Bessent said in a long post on X.

The price of Brent crude has witnessed sharp swings from roughly \$70 per barrel before the war began to as high as \$119.50 this week.

“Today, the Department of the Treasury is issuing a narrowly tailored, short-term authorisation permitting the sale of Iranian oil currently stranded at sea,” Bessent said.

The US official claimed that at present, sanctioned Iranian oil is being hoarded by China on the cheap. By temporarily unlocking this existing Continued on P4

COMMERCIAL LPG BOOSTED TO 50%

The government has approved an additional 20 per cent allocation of commercial LPG to states and Union Territories, taking the total allocation to 50 per cent, as increased domestic output is helping the situation crawl back to normalcy.

See P2



PM to Iran: Keep shipping lanes open

Extends Eid, Nowruz greetings; condemns infrastructure attacks

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: As the Hormuz crisis continues, Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Saturday spoke to Iran’s President, Masoud Pezeshkian, and reaffirmed the importance of safeguarding freedom of navigation.

Following attacks by Israel on Iran’s largest gas field, South Pars, and retaliatory strikes, including on Qatar’s key Ras Laffan LNG complex, the Prime Minister also spoke out against the targeting of critical infrastructure, emphasising that it threatens stability and disrupts crucial supply chains.

In a post on X on Saturday, PM Modi wrote, “Spoke with President Dr. Masoud Pezeshkian and conveyed Eid and Nowruz greetings. We expressed hope that this festive season brings peace, stability and prosperity to West Asia. Condemned attacks on critical



HOTLINE TALK

» In his telephonic conversation with the Iranian leader, PM Modi conveyed Eid and Nowruz greetings, expressing hope that this festive season brings peace, stability and prosperity to West Asia

» The prime minister also appreciated Iran’s continued support for the safety and security of Indian nationals in Iran

» This was the second telephonic conversation between Prime Minister Modi and the Iranian President since the present conflict started on February 28

infrastructure in the region, which threaten regional stability and disrupt global supply chains.”

PM Modi condemned the attacks on critical infrastructure in West Asia, while stressing the importance of safeguarding freedom of navigation and ensuring shipping lanes remain open and secure.

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“Spoke with President Dr Masoud Pezeshkian and conveyed Eid and Nowruz greetings. We expressed hope that this festive season brings peace, stability and prosperity to West Asia,” the prime minister said in a post on ‘X’.

The prime minister also appreciated Iran’s continued support for the safety and security of Indian nationals in Iran.

This was the second telephonic conversation between Prime Minister Modi and the Iranian President since the present conflict started on February 28.

On March 12, President Pezeshkian briefed Prime Minister Modi on Continued on P4

HIGHWAY BLOCKED, STONE PELTING FOLLOWS

Crash death leads to Mathura unrest

BISWAJEET BANERJEE

MATHURA: Mathura witnessed tension and sporadic violence after the death of a local cow vigilante, popularly known as ‘Farsa Wale Baba’, triggered protests and stone pelting on the Delhi highway in the Chhata area.

According to officials, angry crowds blocked the highway early in the morning, leading to long traffic snarls and panic among commuters. Despite police intervention, the situation flared up repeatedly, keeping the area on edge for several hours.

The administration said the incident stemmed from a road accident amid dense fog. A truck carrying metal wires with a Rajasthan registration allegedly rammed into a container from behind. The impact proved fatal for the vigilante, who died on the spot. The truck driver was injured and the vehicle sustained heavy damage.



AFTER THE DEATH OF LOCAL COW VIGILANTE ‘FARSA WALE BABA’

However, tensions escalated after allegations surfaced that the victim had been deliberately run over by cattle smugglers. The claim quickly spread among locals, intensifying anger and leading to large-scale protests.

Officials said the deceased, known in the region for his cow protection activities, was reportedly inspecting a container with his Continued on P4

KEY POINTS

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Raymond boss hurt in Maldives accident

MALE: Raymond Group Chairman & Managing Director Gautam Hari Singhania has sustained injuries, while two Indian nationals are reported missing after a speedboat capsized near Felidhoo island in the Maldives, according to local media reports.

There were seven people on board at the time of the incident near Vaavu atoll early Friday morning. Two women – a British national and a Russian national – and five Indian men were on board, the Edition.mv reported.

Police said five people fell into the sea when the vessel overturned, including the Russian woman and four Indian men. Singhania, 60, who was among the tourists, has been rescued. Citing police, news portal Adhathu reported that he sustained minor injuries in the accident. He was discharged from the hospital after treatment, it added. “The two missing persons are Indian nationals,” police said, adding that search operations are on.

“The speedboat belongs to his yacht, TT Ashena. The Maldivian Coast Guard is still looking for two people who went missing in the accident,” Adhathu reported. Citing sources, it said that the vessel involved in the accident was a Cigarette racing boat designed to be driven at high speeds.

Maldives National Defence Force’s Male Area Command Coast Guard Second Squadron is searching for the missing individuals. The incident occurred about two nautical miles southwest of Keyodhoo, MNDF said. AGENCIES

CELEBRATIONS



Children from the Muslim community exchange greetings at Jama Masjid on the occasion of Eid Al-Fitr, in New Delhi, on Saturday PTI

COVERS 90 OF 126 SEATS

BJP adds two more Assam nominees

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI/ GUWAHATI: The BJP on Saturday announced the names of two more candidates for the April 9 Assembly elections in Assam, fielding Krishna Saha from Dalgaoon and Jiban Gogoi from Sissibargaon, party sources said.

With this, the saffron party has fielded its candidates for 90 seats in the 126-member Assam Assembly.

Speculations were rife that the wife of the BJP’s Lakhimpur MP Pradan Baruah might

be fielded from Sissibargaon for the Assembly polls. The Sissibargaon seat falls under the Lakhimpur Lok Sabha constituency.

However, Jiban Gogoi, a local leader of the party, made the cut.

The BJP is contesting the state polls in alliance with Asom Gana Parishad (AGP) and Bodoland People’s Front (BPF). AGP got 26 seats while the BPF got 11 in its share as a pre-poll arrangement. The remaining seats are in the BJP’s share.

Both the BJP and AGP

ALSO NAMES NINE CANDIDATES FOR PUDUCHERRY POLLS

have named candidates for the Chamaria seat.

The BJP announced its first list of 88 candidates on Thursday, fielding Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma in Jalukbari, and incumbent MLA Hitendra Nath Goswami against state Congress chief Gaurav Gogoi in Jorhat.

The Cabinet ministers who

have been renominated from their seats include Ajanta Neog from Golaghat, Ranoo Pegu from Dhemaji (ST), Rupesh Gowala from Doomdooma, Bimal Borah from Tingkhong, Pijush Hazarika from Jagirao (SC), Jayanta Malla Baruah from Nalbari, Ashok Singhal from Dhekiajuli, Krishendu Paul from Patharkandi and Kaushik Rai from Lakhipur.

Pradyut Bordoloi and Bhupen Borah, who recently joined the BJP from the Congress, will contest from Dispur and Bihpuria, respectively. Continued on P4

PIL RAISES CONCERN OVER POLICE UPLOADS

SC flags social media threat to fair trials

OUR CORRESPONDENT

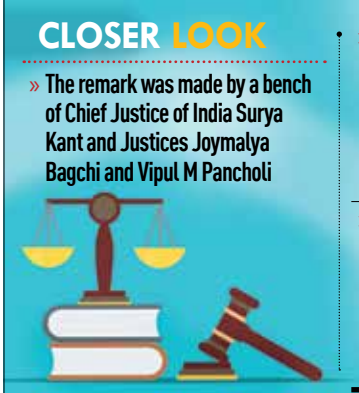
NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court has expressed its concern over the trend of people instantly uploading videos shot on mobile phones on social media and said that such activities pose a serious threat to a fair trial.

The remark was made by a bench of Chief Justice of India Surya Kant and Justices Joydymalya Bagchi and Vipul M Panchohi on Friday.

The bench was hearing a PIL that alleged that police upload videos and photographs of the accused on social media and create a bias in people’s minds.

The PIL argued that the court, in another case, had already asked the states to frame guidelines for media briefing by the police, and it would cover social media posts as well.

The bench suggested the petitioner Hemendra Patel to await



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the outcome of those guidelines, and agreed with senior advocate Gopal Sankaranarayanan, appearing for Patel, that every person nowadays with a mobile phone has become media.

The senior counsel flagged the recent trend of police posting the images of accused persons

being handcuffed, tied by ropes, paraded, forced to kneel, etc, on social media, which, apart from causing an affront to personal dignity, adds to the public bias.

Justice Bagchi told Sankaranarayanan that instead of talking of police, which have been given three months to formu-

late a standard operating procedure on police media briefings, he should seek a comprehensive mechanism for police, conventional, and social media.

The judge said, on a larger canvas, the court believes police should not create a bias against the accused through briefings.

“Police can be restrained through the SOP. But what about the media, especially social media, and the public? Can they be restrained? Comparatively, TV channels are much more restrained, even though one might disagree with their views,” Justice Bagchi observed.

The present issue may require broader consideration extending beyond the immediate question raised in the petition, he said.

Justice Bagchi told Sankaranarayanan, “We understand that police briefings to the media must be responsible Continued on P4

Govt decides to remove domestic airfare caps

To be effective from March 23

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI/ MUMBAI: The government has removed temporary caps on domestic airfares that were imposed in the wake of the IndiGo flight disruptions in December last year.

The airfare caps removal will be effective from March 23, according to an order issued by the civil aviation ministry.

The removal also comes at a time when airlines are facing significant operational disruptions in international routes due to the West Asia conflict.

In the order, the ministry also said that airlines are required to exercise pricing discipline and act responsibly. “Airlines shall ensure that fares remain reasonable, trans-

The removal also comes at a time when airlines are facing significant operational disruptions in international routes due to the West Asia conflict

parent and commensurate with market conditions, and that passenger interests are not adversely impacted,” it said.

The ministry also stressed that any instance of excessive or unjustified surge in fares, if observed particularly during periods of peak demand, disruptions, or exigencies, would be viewed seriously.

Continued on P4



West Asia crisis must be resolved through dialogue and diplomacy
Rajnath Singh

In today’s paper

BUSINESS

FINMIN MODIFIES MCGS FOR MSMEs 2

CITY

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NATION

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INTERNATIONAL

RUSSIAN STRIKE ON ZAPORIZHZHIA KILLS 2 6

SPORT

KOHLI FIRES UP RCB 7

Commercial LPG allocation hiked to 50% as domestic output improves

The War in the Middle East disrupted energy supplies to India, leading to initial curtailment in LPG supplies to commercial establishments

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The government has approved an additional 20 per cent allocation of commercial LPG to states and Union Territories, taking the total allocation to 50 per cent, as increased domestic output is helping the situation crawl back to normalcy.

The three-week-long war in the Middle East disrupted energy supplies to India, leading to initial curtailment in LPG supplies to commercial establishments like hotels to prioritize supplies to household kitchens.

Later, a fifth of their supplies were restored, and the government offered an additional 10 per cent, subject to states expediting piped gas projects.

On Saturday, the government announced a 20 per cent enhanced allocation to key sectors such as restaurants, hotels, industrial canteens, food processing units, community kitchens and subsidised food outlets, while also supporting migrant workers through targeted distribution.

The additional allocation



Later, a fifth of their supplies were restored, and the government offered an additional 10 per cent, subject to states expediting piped gas projects

will be subject to commercial establishments registering with oil companies and applying for a piped natural gas connection, according to a letter written by the oil secretary to states.

An official statement said domestic LPG supply remains stable, with no reported shortages at distributorships and

normal delivery operations continuing.

Panic bookings have declined, and citizens have been advised to avoid crowding and rely on home delivery.

To ease supply pressures, the government is also promoting a shift towards piped natural gas (PNG), particularly for com-

Highlights

» Additional allocation will be subject to commercial establishments registering with oil firms & applying for a piped natural gas connection

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» To ease supply pressures, govt is also promoting shift towards PNG, particularly for commercial establishments

mercial establishments, and has urged states to expedite approvals for city gas distribution networks. In parallel, all refineries are operating at high capacity with adequate crude inventories, ensuring sufficient availability of petrol and diesel.

No fuel shortages have been reported at retail outlets, and the

public has been advised against panic buying, it said.

Natural gas supplies to priority segments, including domestic PNG and CNG transport, are being fully maintained, while industrial consumers are receiving about 80 per cent of their usual supply.

Additional steps include increased domestic LPG production, extended booking intervals, and allocation of extra kerosene supplies to states to provide alternative fuel options.

States and Union Territories have been directed to maintain strict vigilance against hoarding and black marketing, it said, adding more than 3,500 raids have been conducted nationwide, leading to the seizure of around 1,400 LPG cylinders.

Most states have also set up control rooms and district-level monitoring committees to oversee supply and distribution.

In the maritime sector, the government said 22 Indian-flagged vessels with 611 seafarers remain in the western Persian Gulf region, with no reported incidents in the past 24 hours.

TO HELP MANUFACTURERS, EXPORTERS FinMin modifies Mutual Credit Guarantee Scheme for MSMEs

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Finance Ministry on Saturday said the Mutual Credit Guarantee Scheme for MSMEs (MCGS-MSME) has been modified to support manufacturers and exporters, allowing a 5 per cent upfront contribution in tranches after the fourth year.

As per the revised scheme, the services sector has been included in the scheme, and the cost of equipment/machinery has been reduced up to 60 per cent of the project cost from the earlier 75 per cent, the finance ministry said in a statement.

The National Credit Guarantee Trustee Company Ltd (NCGTC) has operationalised the revised scheme since February 24, 2026.

According to the modified scheme, the credit guarantee would expire after 10 years, as compared to the unspecified period in the earlier scheme.

Elaborating on eligibility, it said, profitable units having exported at least 25 per cent of their sales turnover in each of the previous 3 financial years and satisfying certain export realisation conditions are eligible to avail the scheme.

Guaranteed loan amount is pegged at Rs 20 crore, and upfront contribution is 2 per cent of the loan amount, a max-



MSMEs contribute around 30 per cent to the GDP and over 45 per cent to the exports of India, and give employment to more than 35 crore workers.

imum of Rs 40 lakh, with 1 per cent each refundable in the 4th and 5th year of the guarantee period.

Guarantee coverage is 75 per cent of the amount in default, and the guarantee fee would be 'nil' for the first year and thereafter, every year, 0.50 per cent of the loan outstanding.

MSMEs contribute around 30 per cent to the GDP and over 45 per cent to the exports

of India, and give employment to more than 35 crore workers.

Achieving the vision of 'Viksit Bharat 2047' requires strong, globally competitive, and sustainable MSMEs.

The modifications in the MCGS-MSME scheme are expected to facilitate increased availability of credit for the purchase of Plant and Machinery/Equipment by MSMEs, including exporter MSMEs, and give a major boost to the manufacturing and export sector in India, it said.

The scheme, launched in January 2025, provides 60 per cent guarantee coverage by NCGTC to Member Lending Institutions (MLIs) for credit facilities up to Rs 100 crore sanctioned to eligible Micro, Small and Medium Enterprises (MSMEs) under MCGS-MSME for the purchase of equipment/ machinery.

Vedanta Ltd reuses 85 million cubic metres water across operations in FY26

NEW DELHI: Vedanta Ltd, the country's leading metals and mining conglomerate, has recycled and reused over 85 million cubic metres of water across its operations in FY26 till February, amid global warnings of a 40 per cent water shortfall by 2030.

The announcement comes a day ahead of World Water Day on March 22, underscoring the company's commitment to scalable water management in a water-stressed world.

In the wake of growing water stress from climate vari-

ability and surging demand, Vedanta is steadfast in responsible water stewardship, ramping up tech-driven efficiency, ecosystem restoration, and community partnerships to achieve full 'Net Water Positive' status by 2030, the company said.

ITC's integrated water stewardship programme revives Sehore lake in MP

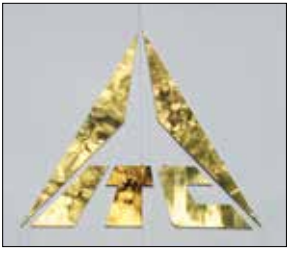
NEW DELHI: A once-dry lake in Molga village of Madhya Pradesh's Sehore district now overflows with water, irrigating nearby soybean fields and transforming livelihoods—thanks to a community-driven water management initiative led by ITC Limited.

The change, visible just 90 minutes from Bhopal, is part of ITC's integrated water stewardship programme that promotes 'Water User Groups' (WUGs).

Built on collective action and behavioural change, the initiative has mobilised villagers—especially women—to revive local water bodies, adopt climate-resilient farming and ensure equitable water use.

Across India, ITC has facilitated over 5,800 such groups, forming the backbone of its watershed development efforts. These initiatives have covered more than 1.89 million acres, benefiting over five lakh people across 17 states.

A key feature of the programme is strong participation by women, who now play an active role in managing water resources, maintaining infrastructure such as ponds, canals and check dams, and ensuring fair distribution.



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Their involvement has been crucial in sustaining over 36,900 water structures created under the initiative. The approach aligns with the theme of World Water Day 2026—"Water and Gender"—which emphasises the role of women in addressing global water challenges.

According to ITC, women's participation has improved transparency, equity and long-term sustainability of water management systems.

Under the programme, women are also leading demand-side management efforts through initiatives like "More Crop Per Drop".

Thousands have been trained as "Krishi Sakshis," promoting micro-irrigation methods such as drip and sprinkler systems and encouraging climate-resilient agriculture. ITC estimates its water-use efficiency initiatives helped save nearly 1,700 million kilolitres of water in 2025-26 alone.

Nearly two lakh women farmers are now part of ITC's agri ecosystem, contributing to efficient water use and community awareness. Improved water availability has also reduced the burden of long-distance water collection, enabling women to engage in income-generating activities and self-help groups.

Local resident Vimla Malvi said access to water has significantly improved daily life. "We used to walk long distances to fetch water. Now, after joining the water user group, we help maintain the village dam and see real change," she said.

Beyond environmental gains, the initiative has driven social transformation, reinforcing the role of women as key stakeholders in sustainable development.

PMMSY gains traction in Punjab, Centre reviews progress in Jalandhar



JALANDHAR: Dr. Abhilash Likhki, Secretary in the Department of Fisheries, GoI, on Saturday reviewed the implementation of the Pradhan Mantri Matsya Sampada Yojana (PMMSY) in Jalandhar, highlighting the state's growing contribution to inland fisheries.

He interacted with beneficiaries availing scheme support, including distribution of scooters with ice boxes, insulated vehicles, and other fisheries-related infrastructure aimed at strengthening last-mile connectivity and market access.

Punjab has recorded notable progress under PMMSY, attracting a total investment of Rs 168 crore, of which Rs 47 crore has been contributed by the Centre. Officials said the initiative is helping boost fish production while improving

livelihoods of local fish farmers.

Likhki also visited a fish pond developed under PMMSY in Village Jaitowali, Jandu Singha, owned by Ahneer Kaur, showcasing the scheme's impact at the grassroots level. Inland fisheries account for over 75 per cent of India's total fish production, currently estimated at 197.75 lakh tonnes, and play a key role in rural employment, nutrition, and export potential.

Freshwater species such as Catla, Rohu, Mrigal, Grass Carp, and Common Carp are widely cultivated in the region and sold in local markets at around Rs 140 per kg, with an average harvest size of 700–800 grams.

Meanwhile, Muktsar Sahib district has been identified by the Centre as a cluster for shrimp farming.

STATE BANK OF INDIA

Home Loan Centre (HLC) C-59 Community Centre, Naraina Industrial Area Phase - 1, New Delhi-110028

DEMAND NOTICE (DECEASED BORROWER)

"SECTION 13(2) OF SARFAESI NOTICE ISSUED TO LEGAL HEIRS OF DECEASED BORROWER"

A notice is hereby given that the loan of the following Borrower/s and Co-Borrowers have been classified as Non-Performing Asset (NPA). The notices were issued to legal heirs under Section 13(2) of Securitization and Re-construction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act 2002 on their last known addresses, but since the borrowers are deceased, a notice to public is given by way of this public notice.

Name of Account/Borrower & Address	Description of the Property Mortgaged / Charged	Date of Notice	NPA DATE	Amount Outstanding as on 20.03.2026
Late Mr. Suraj Bhan Auto Loan A/c. No. 41373437462	Hypothecation of - MARUTI ERTIGA VXI (0) CNG CHASSIS NO.: MA3BNC62SNH521369 ENGINE NO.: K15CN9083773 REGN. NO.: DL 10CU 3691 DATED 23/10/2022	20.03.2026	23.02.2026	Rs. 4,16,569/- (Rupees Four Lakh Sixteen Thousand Five Hundred Sixty Nine Only) as on 20.03.2026 + further interest

The steps are being taken for substituted service of notice. The legal heirs of the above Borrower(s) and/or their Guarantor(s) (whenever applicable) are hereby called upon to make payment of Outstanding amount within 60 days from the date of publication of this notice, failing which further steps will be taken after expiry of 60 days from the date of this notice under sub-section (4) of Section 13 of Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002.

The all legal heirs of the borrowers attention is invited to provisions of Sub-section(8) of Section 13 of the Act, in respect of time available to redeem the secured assets.

DATE: 20.03.2026 PLACE: NEW DELHI

Sd/- Authorized Officer, State Bank of India, Home Loan Centre, Naraina, New Delhi

CAN FIN HOMES LTD.

CIN : L85110KA1987PLC008699

Above Canara Bank Building, First Floor, Plot No C-3, Sector-1, Noida, Uttar Pradesh, Pin Code : 201301.

E-mail : noida@canfinhomes.com, Ph No : 0120-2970164/65/67, 7625079126

APPENDIX-IV-A [See Proviso To Rule 9(1)] Sale Notice For Sale of Immovable Properties

E-Auction Sale Notice for Sale of Immovable Assets under the Securitisation and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 read with proviso to Rule 9(1) of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002

NOTICE is hereby given to the public in general and in particular to the Borrower (s) and Guarantor (s) that the below described immovable property mortgaged/charged to the Secured Creditor, the possession of which has been taken by the Authorised Officer of Can Fin Homes Ltd, Noida Branch, will be sold by holding E-Auction on "As is where is", "As is what is", and "Whatever here is" on 13.04.2026 for recovery of mentioned hereinafter due to canfin homes Ltd. from respective Borrowers and Guarantors as on the respective dates together with further interest and other charges thereon.

Sr. No.	Name of Borrower and Guarantor	Liability Amount as on 21.03.2026	Reserve Price	Earnest Money Deposit	Type of Possession	Description of the Property
1.	RAKHU W/O OMBIR AND OMBIR S/O LAKHMI (Borrowers) and RAVINDER S/O DHARAMVEER (Guarantors)	Rs. 17,57,556/- (Rupees Seventeen Lakh Fifty Seven Thousand Five Hundred FiftySix Only)	Rs. 10,00,000/- (Rupees Eleven Lakh Only)	Rs.1,10,000/- (Rupees One Lakh Ten Thousand Only)	Physical Possession	PLOT A- 1/215, ENTIRE GROUND FLOOR, DLF DILSHAD EXT-II HADBAST, COVER AREA-30.09 Sq. Mtr, VILLAGE- BRAHMPUR URF BHOUPURA, GHAZIABAD, U.P.-201005. Bounded by: East: 25 ft Wide Road West: Plot Digar North: Plot No. A-1/216 South: Plot No. A-1/214 Known encumbrances- Nil
2.	SAPNA SINGH W/O VINOD SINGH AND VINOD SINGH S/O VINOOD SINGH (Borrowers) and PRAVEEN OJHA S/O SURESH OJHA (Guarantors)	Rs. 11,88,111/- (Rupees Eleven Lakh Eighty Eight Thousand Eleven Hundred Eleven Only)	Rs. 11,50,000/- (Rupees Eleven Lakh Fifty Thousand Only)	Rs.1,15,000/- (Rupees One Lakh Fifteen Thousand Only)	PHYSICAL POSSESSION	RESIDENTIAL FLAT NO-406, WITHOUT ROOF, FOURTH FLOOR, KHASRANO-3KAAND3 KHA, PLOT NO-35 TO 52, KRISHNA RESIDENCY-2, VILLAGE- CHAPRAULA, DISTRICT- SHANKAR VATIKA, PARGANA AND TEHSIL-DADRI, DISTRICT- GB NAGAR, U.P. Bounded by: East: Gallery West: 20 ft wide road North: Flat No-407 South: Flat no-405 known encumbrances- Nil

The detailed terms and conditions of the sale are provided in the official website of Can Fin Homes Ltd., Link for participating in e-auction : www.auctionbazaar.com

Date: 21.03.2026 Place: Noida

Sd/- Authorized Officer Can Fin Homes Ltd.

Bharat Electricity Summit 2026: Bihar showcases power sector transformation

The state aims to achieve 24 GW of renewable energy capacity by 2030 & attract investments exceeding Rs 81,000 crore across power value chain over the next five years

NEW DELHI: The Government of Bihar hosted a dedicated state session titled "Powering Bihar's Growth: Innovation, Inclusion & Investment" at Yashobhoomi, highlighting its progress in transforming the power sector and outlining an ambitious roadmap for sustainable growth.

As a Focus State Partner at the summit, Bihar showcased significant improvements in financial and operational performance of its power utilities.

The session was attended by senior officials and industry leaders, including Manoj Kumar Singh, IAS, Secretary, Energy, Government of Bihar & CMD, BSPHCL and other key representatives from state utilities and the energy sector.

The programme began with a welcome address by SBPDCL and BSPGCL Managing Director Mahendra Kumar, followed by a film on Bihar's energy journey.

CLOSER LOOK

» As a Focus State Partner at the summit, Bihar showcased significant improvements in financial and operational performance of its power utilities

» The state has also witnessed a sharp rise in power demand, with peak demand exceeding 8,700 MW in FY26, reflecting improved supply and economic growth

» Distribution companies have reduced AT&C losses to around 15.5 per cent, alongside gains in billing and collection efficiency

A detailed presentation by Singh highlighted the sector's turnaround, noting that the State Transmission Utility moved from a loss of Rs 342 crore in financial year 2013-14 to a profit of Rs 2,004 crore in financial year 2024-25.

The state has also witnessed a sharp rise in power demand, with peak demand exceeding 8,700 MW in FY26, reflecting improved supply and economic growth.

Distribution companies

have reduced AT&C losses to around 15.5 per cent, alongside gains in billing and collection efficiency.

Bihar has emerged as a leader in smart prepaid metering, installing over 87 lakh meters to enhance transparency and revenue realisation.

Looking ahead, the state aims to achieve 24 GW of renewable energy capacity by 2030 and attract investments exceeding Rs 81,000 crore

across the power value chain over the next five years.

A panel discussion featuring industry leaders from organisations such as NTPC, Adani Group, ACME Solar, Secure Meters, Greenko and L&T explored investment opportunities and policy support.

Participants expressed strong confidence in Bihar's evolving energy ecosystem.

Singh assured investors of a supportive regulatory environment, faster approvals and reduced project gestation periods, particularly under the tariff-based competitive bidding route.

He also reaffirmed the state's commitment to completing the rollout of remaining smart prepaid meters.

The session concluded with a vote of thanks, reinforcing Bihar's focus on innovation-driven, inclusive and investment-led growth in the energy sector.

Delhi’s Super 56: CM Gupta felicitates UPSC qualifiers

‘Insights from them will help in policy-making’

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Saturday felicitated 56 candidates who cleared the civil services examination and said the Delhi government is working to give every student access to quality education, proper guidance, and the necessary resources for competitive exams.

The ceremony ‘Delhi ke Gaurav: UPSC Achievers Felicitation Ceremony 2026’ was organised for the first time by the government in collaboration with the revenue department and was held at the Mukhyamantri Janseva Sadan.

During her address, Gupta said, “Our goal is to produce a large number of IAS, IPS officers, doctors, and engineers from the capital every year.”

She affirmed that the Delhi Government is continuously working to make the capital’s education system more robust, inclusive, and competitive, ensuring that a significant

Highlights

» The ceremony ‘Delhi ke Gaurav: UPSC Achievers Felicitation Ceremony 2026’ was organised for the first time by the government in collaboration with the revenue department

» She affirmed that the Delhi Government is continuously working to make the capital’s education system more robust

dates’ relentless hard work, discipline, and unwavering determination, Gupta emphasised that this achievement is not merely a personal success but a significant step toward nation-building.

“These newly selected officers will serve as the backbone of the country’s administrative system and will play a crucial role in taking developmental schemes to the person at the last mile of society,” the chief minister added.

During the programme, Gupta discussed preparation experiences, challenges, and suggestions with the 56 selected candidates and said, “The insights of the youth serve as a guide for the government and will be incorporated into policy-making to provide better opportunities for future generations.”

Chief Secretary Rajiv Verma and Divisional Commissioner Neeraj Semwal were among the dignitaries present on the occasion.



Rekha Gupta poses with the qualifiers during the felicitation ceremony

PTI

MCD speeds up construction & demolition plant set-up

NEW DELHI: The Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) has stepped up efforts to expedite the setting up of the Tehkhand construction and demolition (C&D) waste processing plant to tackle the issue of debris in the city. December 2026 has been set as the deadline for its construction.

Officials said that the upcoming facility near Okhla will add 1,000 metric tonnes per day to the existing processing capacity, which currently stands at around 5,000 metric tonnes, even as Delhi generates 7,000 metric tonnes of C&D waste. Officials said that many times the shortfall has led to frequent accumulation of debris across the capital, contributing to air pollution. Officials added that a detailed action plan to improve collection and disposal was recently submitted to the state government, while directions from the central government have led to intensified clearance drives.

“There was a target to lift one lakh metric tonnes of debris within 15 days. Around 80,000 metric tonnes has already been cleared in 12 days and sent to processing plants,” an official said.

AGENCIES

NDMC fast-tracks PNG expansion amid gas crisis

ANAMTA FATIMA

NEW DELHI: The New Delhi Municipal Council has initiated a series of measures to accelerate the expansion of Piped Natural Gas (PNG) connections across its jurisdiction, aiming to ensure cleaner and more accessible fuel for residents and establishments.

The move comes amid disruptions in conventional fuel supply and is expected to promote PNG as a reliable and environmentally friendly alternative. The civic body has granted a three-month waiver on road restoration charges for pipeline-laying works undertaken by Indraprastha Gas Limited, a step intended to reduce procedural delays and encourage faster infrastructure rollout.

According to officials, permissions for road cutting related to PNG pipeline installation will now be issued within 24 hours of receiving complete applications. Departments have been directed to maintain close coordination to ensure seamless execution of projects and minimise inconvenience to the public.

The council has also instructed that all excavation sites be promptly backfilled and restored within a fixed timeframe to prevent traffic disruptions

The council has also instructed that all excavation sites be promptly backfilled and restored within a fixed timeframe to prevent traffic disruptions and safety hazards. Road divisions have been asked to prioritise restoration work to maintain normalcy in affected areas.

The initiative is expected to significantly enhance the pace of PNG connectivity in New Delhi, ensuring wider access to clean energy while reducing dependence on conventional fuels. Officials said the decision reflects a citizen-centric approach, balancing infrastructure development with public convenience and environmental sustainability.



degrees Celsius and 13 degrees Celsius

Delhi warms up despite chilly winds

Air quality deteriorated to the moderate category again

NEW DELHI: Even as the maximum temperature of Delhi saw a significant increase on Saturday, the national capital remained under the influence of chilly winds, a day after Delhi recorded its coldest March day in six years and the cleanest air day in five months.

Safdarjung, representative of Delhi’s weather, recorded a minimum of 13 degrees Celsius, 3.5 degrees below the normal and a drop from 16 degrees Celsius recorded on Friday.

The maximum temperature was recorded at 27.4 degrees

In Short

» Safdarjung, representative of Delhi’s weather, recorded a minimum of 13 degrees Celsius, 3.5 degrees below the normal

» Lodhi Road recorded a maximum and minimum temperature of 27

Celsius, 3.9 degrees above the normal and a 5.7 degrees increase from Friday’s max-

imum temperature of 21.7 degrees Celsius.

Delhi had logged its cold-

A DAY TO REMEMBER

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta met Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Saturday and discussed the national capital’s all-around development. “I had the privilege of a heartfelt meeting with the Honourable Prime Minister Narendra Modi during which I received his invaluable guidance. His visionary leadership and special affection for Delhi always fill us with fresh energy and inspiration,” Gupta said in a post on X.

PIC/X

Vijender Gupta reviews Budget session preparedness

NEW DELHI: Ahead of the Budget Session of the Delhi Legislative Assembly, Speaker Vijender Gupta on Friday stressed the need for “shared dignity” of the House, while reviewing the preparedness of the assembly. “The forthcoming Budget session must reflect the finest parliamentary traditions, where debate is informed, conduct is measured, and every intervention contributes meaningfully to public purpose,” Gupta said.

The second part of the Fourth Session (Budget Session) of the Eighth Legislative Assembly will be held from March 23 to March 25, he added. The speaker assessed operational and procedural readiness.

AGENCIES

Eid prayers held in Uttam Nagar amid heavy police security



Muslims offer prayers on Eid al-Fitr, at Uttam Nagar, on Saturday

PTI

NEW DELHI: Muslims offered Eid-ul-Fitr prayers in west Delhi’s Uttam Nagar on Saturday under heavy security, with the area witnessing a subdued celebration days after a localised clash left a man dead and triggered tensions.

A video circulating on social media shows two men carrying a bag filled with flower petals and showering them on police and Rapid Action Force (RAF) personnel, while a someone in the background is heard saying, “The cops gave full support.”

Another person can also be heard saying, “They did a fantastic job.”

Meanwhile, police detained around 95 people for raising provocative slogans and trying to disturb law and order.

A heavy deployment of Delhi Police and paramilitary personnel is in place across Hastal village and nearby areas, with barricades set up at key entry and exit points and strict identity checks being carried out, police said.

Only residents are being allowed access to certain stretches after verification, while the movement of outsiders is restricted. Police teams also conducted regular foot patrols and are monitoring rooftops, narrow lanes and other sensitive pockets through CCTV cameras to prevent any untoward incident.

Deputy Commissioner of Police (Dwarka) Kushal Pal

Singh said the situation is calm. “The environment here is peaceful. People offered namaz without any disturbance. We have maintained tight security in the area and are continuing routine patrols and picketing,” he said, urging people not to believe rumours on social media. Despite the heavy security presence, residents said prayers were conducted peacefully, though celebrations were low key.

Parvez, a resident, said the spirit of communal harmony remained intact. “We offered namaz peacefully. Our Hindu friends are expected to join us, and we’re looking forward to celebrating together. We are saddened by what happened to Tarun (victim of the March 4 incident); he was like a brother to us. However, the situation on the ground is not as tense as it has been portrayed (on social media). Our neighbours have been very kind, and the police have ensured adequate security,” he said.

Another resident, Moham-mad Naveen, said the atmosphere was still somewhat tense. “It doesn’t feel the same due to the environment created by outsiders, along with heavy police deployment. We are celebrating Eid under some tension. That said, we are grateful to the Delhi Police for maintaining law and order, which has allowed us to celebrate safely,” he said.

MP0ST

Sector 85 Gurugram link road opened, eases access for residents

OUR CORRESPONDENT

GURUGRAM: Residents of Sector 85 have received long-awaited relief with the opening of a 24-metre sector road connecting the area to the multi-utility corridor and Dwarka Expressway. The lack of a proper link had forced thousands of families to depend on narrow, congested internal roads for years.

The issue was addressed during a District Public Grievance & Redressal Committee meeting chaired by Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini. A breakthrough was achieved after Godrej Properties acquired the private land parcel blocking the road and facilitated its opening for public use.

Haryana Minister Rao Narbir Singh thanked government officials and Godrej Properties



for their efforts in resolving the long-pending issue. Gurugram Deputy Commissioner Ajay Kumar also acknowledged the collaborative effort involving the administration, the company, and local stakeholders.

Geetika Trehan, CEO – North Zone, Godrej Properties, said the initiative improves connectivity, safety, and convenience for residents.

She said: “This government and administration led initiative addresses a long-standing access challenge in Sector 85. Godrej Properties is pleased to have supported its execution.

The new 24-metre road significantly improves connectivity, and enhances everyday safety and convenience for residents.

Wing Commander (Retd) RD Deshpande, secretary, RAWs(Rise Always Welfare Society), said: “The road opening has brought a sense of relief to residents and passer-by. It is good to witness that authorities are listening to what the community is saying and doing something about it. We are very thankful, district authorities and Godrej Properties who helped fix this long-pending issue.

Themed forests to boost green cover in city

NEW DELHI: The Delhi government is planning a series of themed forests or “special vans”, including those based on zodiac signs, stars and ancient traditions to enhance the city’s green cover while blending ecology with cultural traditions, officials said.

The proposed plantations, to come up on around more than two acres of land in select pockets of the Central and South Ridge, are part of efforts to create green spaces rooted in traditional concepts.

The planned forests include Ritu Van, Nakshatra Van, Rashi Van, Thirthankar Van, Bel Van and Panchvati Van, each based on a distinct cultural or ecological theme.

“These forests will enhance plantations in the national capital, add ecological value, and attract more people to forest areas while educating them about different cultural aspects in an engaging manner,” an official said. Explaining the concept further, he said, “Under Ritu Van, trees linked to different seasons will be planted so people can actually see how flowering and foliage change through the year.” He said the Nakshatra Van will have plants linked to different stars and constellations.

AGENCIES



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PEACEFUL PROTESTS SEEK END TO WEST ASIA CONFLICT

Eid al-Fitr celebrated across the country with prayers and feasts

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Eid al-Fitr was celebrated across India on Saturday with special prayers for peace, progress and brotherhood at large congregations in mosques and eidgahs, followed by peaceful protests in several parts of the country condemning the US-Israel attacks on Iran and seeking an immediate end to the hostilities in West Asia.

From the busy lanes of Old Delhi to the eidgahs in Jammu and Kashmir and the bustling Nakhoda Masjid in Kolkata, lakhs of faithful dressed in their best embraced each other and exchanged 'seviyan' to celebrate the festival that marked the end of the fasting month of Ramzan.

Greeting the citizens, Prime Minister Narendra Modi said in a post on X, "Best wishes on Eid-ul-Fitr. May this day further brotherhood and kindness all around. May everyone be happy and healthy. Eid Mubarak!"

Chief ministers, including Omar Abdullah of J&K and Mamata Banerjee of West Bengal, governors and other prominent leaders in different states also extended their greetings to the people, and attended the Eid festivities.

In Delhi, people flocked to mosques across the capital to offer namaz, embracing the spirit of unity and devotion, even as a blanket of fog hung over several parts of the city, creating a striking visual against the backdrop of mosque domes and minarets.

The sense of celebration was palpable as people exchanged greetings after offering namaz, with mosques such as the Jama



Muslim children cheer as they play after prayers on the occasion of Eid al-Fitr, at an Eidgah in Bhopal, Madhya Pradesh on Saturday

PTI

Masjid, Fatehpuri Masjid, and those in Seelampur, Okhla and Nizamuddin witnessing a significant turnout.

Uttam Nagar in west Delhi, however, saw subdued celebrations, days after a clash on the day of Holi left a man dead and triggered communal tension in the area.

Heavy deployment of Delhi Police and paramilitary personnel was in place across Hastals village, where the incident took place on March 4, with barricades at key entry and exit points and movement of outsiders restricted.

Despite the heavy security presence, residents said they offered prayers peacefully, though the celebrations were low-key this time.

In J&K, Eid was celebrated across the Union territory with the largest gatherings assembling at the Hazratbal shrine on the banks of Dal Lake in Srinagar, and the eidgah on Resi-

dency Road in Jammu.

However, the authorities did not allow Eid prayers at the historic Jama Masjid at Nowhatta in the Old City area of Srinagar for the seventh year in a row.

Terming the development "unfortunate", Chief Minister Abdullah, who offered prayers at Hazratbal along with his father Farooq Abdullah, said, "On one hand, they claim that everything is normal, and on the other, they close the historic mosque. What kind of normalcy is this? I hope such decisions will be changed in future."

He also said the "illegal" war imposed by the United States and Israel on the world should end at the earliest.

While the authorities tightened security in the vulnerable areas of the Valley fearing anti-US and anti-Israel demonstrations after Eid prayers, people took out peaceful protests in several parts of Kashmir, con-

Highlights

» In Delhi, people flocked to mosques across the capital to offer namaz, embracing the spirit of unity and devotion

» In J&K, Eid was celebrated across the UT with the largest gatherings assembling at the Hazratbal shrine

» In Sambhal, Kaushambi, Deoria and Amethi the festival was celebrated peacefully amid tight security

demning the attacks on Iran and calling for an end to the West Asia conflict.

Marches in solidarity with Iran were taken out in Budgam, Bandipora and other places, with protesters raising slogans against the US-Israel alliance and in support of the Iranian regime, carrying photos of its slain Supreme Leader, Ali Khamenei.

Dressed in new clothes, Muslims of all ages assembled at the eidgahs, mosques and shrines across Uttar Pradesh to offer Eid prayers and exchange greetings.

In Lucknow, the main congregation was held at the Aishbagh Eidgah, where a large number of worshippers offered namaz, with special prayers for peace, progress and brotherhood around the world.

Leaders from different communities, including Christians and Sikhs, also attended the gathering, sources said.

Political leaders, including Samajwadi Party chief Akhilesh Yadav, state Congress president Ajay Rai, and BJP Rajya Sabha MP Dinesh Sharma visited the eidgah and extended their greetings to people.

Reports from Sambhal, Kaushambi, Deoria and Amethi indicated that the festival was celebrated peacefully amid tight security.

Some worshippers were seen offering prayers wearing black armbands to protest against the attacks on Iran.

Similar peaceful protests marked Eid celebrations in various parts of Rajasthan, with members of the Muslim community demonstrating in Jaipur and other districts.

In Jaipur, women and children took out a march, raising slogans against the US and Israel and expressing grief over the reported deaths in Iran.

Similar demonstrations were also reported from Sikar and Ajmer, where people offered Eid prayers wearing black bands as a mark of protest.

Black flags were also put up at some mosques, amid anti-US and anti-Israel sloganeering.

Despite the protests, Eid prayers were offered peacefully across Rajasthan, with people praying for peace and greeting each other.

Peaceful protests were also held in Madhya Pradesh, where many Shias refrained from celebrating Eid denouncing the killing of Iran's Supreme Leader Ali Khamenei. However, members of the Sunni community celebrated the festival with fervour by flooding the eidgahs across the state.

Rainfall at several places in north, fog returns in Delhi

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Several states in north India, including Rajasthan and Himachal Pradesh, received light to moderate rainfall, and fog returned in Delhi on Saturday.

Delhi woke up to a shroud of fog on Saturday with the minimum temperature dipping to 13 degrees Celsius, 3.5 degrees below the normal, as a chilly wind swept the city.

Even as the maximum temperature in Delhi saw a significant increase, the national capital remained under the influence of chilly winds, a day after Delhi recorded its coldest March day in six years and the cleanest air day in five months.

Safdarjung recorded a minimum of 13 degrees Celsius, 3.5 degrees below the normal and a drop from 16 degrees Celsius recorded on Friday. The maximum temperature was recorded at 27.4 degrees Celsius, 3.9 degrees above the normal and a 5.7 degrees increase from Friday's maximum temperature of 21.7 degrees Celsius.

The air quality index (AQI) stood at 94 (satisfactory) at 8 am on Saturday. The air quality is likely to be in the 'moderate' category from Saturday to March 23, according to the Air Quality Early Warning System.

While no rain was recorded on Saturday, the Met department said that strong surface winds of speed 20-30 kmph continued throughout the day. Forecasts by IMD suggest the possibility of very light rain on Monday, along with thunderstorms and lightning during the forenoon to afternoon hours.

Parts of eastern Rajasthan received light to moderate rainfall in the past 24 hours, with



Even as maximum temperature in Delhi saw a significant increase, the national capital remained under the influence of chilly winds

Mandawa in the Jhunjhunu district the wettest at 18 mm, the local meteorological centre said on Saturday.

According to the weather office, the maximum temperature in most parts of the state ranged between 26 degrees and 30 degrees Celsius, two to eight degrees below normal, with Jaisalmer recording the highest temperature at 30.6 degrees Celsius.

Under the partial influence of a weak western disturbance, light rain accompanied by thunder is likely in parts of western Rajasthan, including Jodhpur, Bikaner and the Shekhawati region, on Sunday, the weather office said.

Uttar Pradesh capital Lucknow remained relatively cool on Sunday with maximum temperature touching 25.9 degrees Celsius, 7.9 degrees below the normal, the meteo-

rological department said. It recorded a minimum temperature of 17.2 degrees Celsius.

Ballia recorded a rainfall of 1.2 mm, while Bahraich and Sultanpur recorded one mm each. Rainfall in traces was recorded in the Lakhimpur Kheri district, the department said. The forecast for Lucknow and its neighbouring areas is partly cloudy sky becoming mainly clear. The maximum and minimum temperature will be 29 and 17 degrees Celsius, respectively.

High altitude tribal areas in Himachal Pradesh experienced moderate to heavy snowfall for the fifth day on Saturday, while some mid and lower areas were lashed by widespread rains, causing a sharp fall in mercury.

However, most parts of the state had a dry day on Saturday and bright sunshine greeted people, providing them relief from inclement weather conditions.

Sangla received 20.5 cm of snow, followed by Kalpa 18.2 cm, Keylong 10.0 cm, Hansa 7.5 cm, Gondla 4 cm and Kukumseri 2.1cm since Friday evening. Kandaghat was the wettest with 50 mm rain, followed by Jattion Barrage, Manali, Shimla, Gohar and Berthin, which received more than 40 mm of rain.

BJD suspends 6 MLAs for cross-voting in RS polls, to seek disqualification from Odisha Assembly

BHUBANESWAR: The BJD on Saturday suspended six of its MLAs for cross-voting during the recent election to four Rajya Sabha seats from Odisha.

The suspended legislators are Chakramani Kanhar (Baliguda), Naba Kishor Mallick (Jayadev), Souvic Biswal (Choudwar-Cuttack), Subasini Jena (Basta), Ramakanta Bhoi (Tirtol) and Devi Ranjan Tripathy (Banki).

The decision was taken at the party's political affairs committee (PAC) meeting presided over by BJD chief Naveen Patnaik.

BJD's disciplinary committee, at its meeting on Friday, had recommended action against the six MLAs for violating party orders and indulging in anti-party activities.

"...The six MLAs are hereby suspended from the party

with immediate effect for their involvement in anti-party activities, including cross-voting, in the recent election to Rajya Sabha, violating the core principle of BJD constitution, which mandates absolute loyalty to the party's collective decisions," the party's office order said.

Opposition chief whip Pramila Mallik said the party would write to the Assembly Speaker seeking disquali-

fication of the six suspended MLAs.

"If required, the party will also take the matter to court," Mallik said.

On March 17, the six MLAs were issued show-cause notices, and they submitted their replies to the party on Friday.

In their replies, the MLAs separately asked the chief whip to withdraw the notices and also threatened to sue her.

In the Rajya Sabha elections, the ruling BJP won two of the four seats while the opposition BJD and a saffron party-backed Independent candidate Dilip Ray bagged one seat each in the biennial polls held last Monday.

The elected RS MPs are Manmohan Samal and Sujet Kumar (BJP), Santrupt Misra (BJD) and Independent nominee Dilip Ray.

The opposition common candidate, Dr Datteshwar Hota, fielded by BJD and supported by Congress and CPI(M), was defeated even after having the required numbers. Hota lost the polls as six BJD MLAs and three Congress MLAs cross-voted in favour of Ray.

Meanwhile, Odisha Pradesh Congress Committee (OPCC) has also suspended three of its MLAs -- Ramesh Jena

(Sanakhemundi), Dasarathi Gomango (Mohana) and Sofia Firdous (Barabati-Cuttack), on charges of anti-party activities and cross-voting.

So far, 11 MLAs who allegedly cross-voted in the Rajya Sabha elections have been placed under suspension.

Besides the six suspended on Saturday, the BJD had earlier taken similar action against Arvind Mohapatra (Patkura

and Sanatan Mahakud (Cham-pua) for anti-party activities.

Now, the number of suspended MLAs in the BJD has increased to eight.

The current position in the 147-member Odisha Assembly is: BJP has 79 members and support of three Independent MLAs, BJD has 42 after suspension of eight MLAs, Congress 11 after suspension of three MLAs, and CPI(M) one. AGENCIES

From Page 1

Iran's N-plant hit...

Britain has not participated in US-Israeli attacks on Iran, but has allowed American bombers to use UK bases to attack Iran's missile sites.

On Friday, the British government said US bombers can also use UK bases, including Diego Garcia, in operations to prevent Iran attacking ships in the Strait of Hormuz. Iran targeted the base before that UK statement.

Iran's official news agency Mizan said there was no leakage after Saturday's strike on the Natanz nuclear facility, nearly 220 kilometres southeast of Tehran.

The facility, Iran's main uranium enrichment site, was hit in the first week of the war and several buildings appeared damaged, according to satellite images. The UN nuclear watchdog — the International Atomic Energy Agency — had said "no radiological consequence" were expected from that earlier strike. Natanz had also been targeted in the 12-day war last June.

The US and Israel have offered shifting rationales for the war, from hoping to foment an uprising that topples Iran's leadership to eliminating its nuclear and missile programmes. There have been no public signs of any such uprising and no end to the war in sight.

On social media, Trump said, "We are getting very close to meeting our objectives as we consider winding down our great Military efforts in the Middle East".

That seemed at odds with his administration's move to bolster its firepower in the region and request another USD 200 billion from Congress to fund the war.

Iran's top military spokesperson, Gen. Abolfazl Shekarchi, warned Friday that "parks, recreational areas and tourist destinations" worldwide will not be safe for the country's enemies. The threat renewed concerns that Tehran may revert to using militant attacks beyond the Middle East as a pressure tactic.

Supreme Leader Ayatollah Mojtaba Khamenei praised Iranians' steadfastness in the face of war in a written statement read on Iranian television to mark Nowruz. Khamenei has not been seen in public since he became supreme leader following Israeli strikes that killed his father, Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, and reportedly wounded him.

The Israeli military said early Saturday that it began a wave of strikes targeting Iran-backed Hezbollah militants in Beirut's southern suburbs.

Israeli strikes targeting Hezbollah in Lebanon have killed more than 1,000 people and displaced more than 1 million, according to the Lebanese government.

More than 1,300 people have been killed in Iran during the war. In Israel, 15 people have been killed by Iranian missiles and four others have died in the occupied West Bank. At least 13 US military members have been killed.

Meanwhile, Russian Foreign Ministry spokesperson Maria Zakharova called strikes on the Natanz nuclear enrichment facility "a brazen violation of international law".

In a statement posted on the ministry's website Saturday, Zakharova said such "irresponsible actions" posed a "real risk of catastrophic disaster throughout the Middle East" and were "clearly aimed at further undermining peace, stability, and security in the region".

In another related development, twenty-two countries on Saturday urged Iran to cease attacks and reopen the Strait of Hormuz.

Countries including the United Arab Emirates, Bahrain, the UK, Germany, France, Japan, South Korea and Australia have condemned Iran's attacks on commercial vessels as well as oil and gas facilities in the region.

"The effects of Iran's actions will be felt by people in all parts of the world, especially the most vulnerable," they said in a joint statement.

US unanchors...

supply for the world, the United States will quickly bring approximately 140 million barrels of oil to global markets, expanding the amount of worldwide energy and helping to relieve the temporary pressures on supply caused by Iran, he said.

"In essence, we will be using the Iranian barrels against Tehran to keep the price down as we continue Operation Epic Fury," Bessent said.

The pause on sanctions on Iranian oil loaded on vessels begins Friday and is set to end on April 19.

Petrol prices have increased from \$3 a gallon in the US before the war began to \$3.99 on Saturday.

"This temporary, short-term authorisation is strictly limited to oil that is already in transit and does not allow new purchases or production," Bessent said.

WITH AGENCY INPUTS

PM to Iran...

the current situation in Iran and shared his perspective on recent developments in the

region. The prime minister had expressed deep concern about the evolving security situation in the region and reiterated India's consistent position that all issues must be resolved through dialogue and diplomacy, according to the Ministry of External Affairs.

Iran also controls the Strait of Hormuz, a key shipping route through which 20 percent of the world's energy is transported. Since the conflict, very few ships have been allowed by Iran to cross it.

Crash death leads to Mathura unrest

associates following a tip-off about cattle smuggling. The container, bearing a Nagaland registration, was later found to be carrying goods such as soap, phenyl and shampoo, ruling out the presence of cattle.

The body was taken to the Ajnok gaushala, where a large number of supporters gathered for final rites. Heavy crowds led to near gridlock on the Chhata-Barsana route, with devotees arriving from nearby districts.

The unrest coincided with Eid morning, adding to concerns over law and order. Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath took note of the incident and directed officials to take strict action against those responsible for the violence.

He asked authorities to fix accountability and ensure that no accused is spared.

Following the directive, police launched a crackdown, conducting raids to identify and detain those involved in stone pelting and vandalism.

Abandoned motorcycles found at the protest site have also been seized.

Agra Range DIG Shailesh Kumar Pandey said the death was the result of a road accident and there was no evidence of cattle being transported.

He added that the situation is now under control and several people have been taken into custody.

Police said strict action will be taken against those involved in spreading rumours and inciting violence, while a detailed investigation into the incident is underway.

BJP adds two more Assam nominees

Among the other recent entrants to the BJP from the Congress, Sashi Kanta Das has been

fielded from the Raha (SC) seat, while Kamalakhya Purkayastha has been named for the Katigorah assembly constituency. Both are incumbent MLAs.

Former AGP MLA Bhupen Roy, who recently joined the BJP, will contest from Abhayapuri.

Meanwhile, the BJP also released a list of nine candidates for the April 9 Assembly polls in Pudukcherry, fielding P M L Kalyanasundaram from Kalapet and G N S Rajasekaran from Thirunallar.

According to the list, A Namassivayam will contest from Mannadipet, V P Ramalingame from Rajbhavan and A Johnkumar from Mudaliarpet seats.

Embalam R Selvam will enter the fray from Manaveli, T K S M Meenatchisundaram from Neravy T R Pattinam, and A Dineshan from Mahe.

E Theeppainthan will seek election from Ous-sudu, a Scheduled Caste reserved seat.

The ruling AINRC and the BJP-AIADMK combine on Friday reached an agreement for the Assembly polls in the Union territory, where the AINRC will contest 16 seats, and the BJP will contest the remaining 14 seats.

The arrangements were finalised after Pudukcherry Chief Minister and AINRC leader N Rangasamy on Friday held talks with BJP leader and Union minister Mansukh Mandaviya at a private hotel here.

The BJP, from its kitty, has allocated two seats each to the AIADMK and the Lakshia Jananayaga Katchi (LJK), AINRC sources said.

Although Rangasamy maintained all along that the LJK headed by Jose Charles Matin should not be accommodated in the NDA headed by the AINRC, the talks with the Central minister ended in the chief minister agreeing to include the LJK in the front.

WITH AGENCY INPUTS

SC flags social media threat to fair trials

and reasonable, and must not be exposed to bias, because in a criminal justice system, the investigating agency is neither pro-victim nor pro-accused."

Sankaranarayanan pointed out that the issue of "media trial" was first addressed by the Supreme Court in the Sahara versus SEBI decision of 2012.

Justice Bagchi said the concern is of police authorities getting carried away during media briefings and the emerging risks of media trials in pending criminal cases.

"It is the duty of the investigating agency to

Govt decides to remove domestic...

On a real-time basis, the ministry is monitoring the airfare trends.

According to the order, the temporary caps on domestic airfares were imposed on December 6 to contain an abnormal surge in ticket prices arising out of large-scale flight disruptions of IndiGo.

"... The prevailing situation has since stabilised, with restoration of capacity and normalisation of operations across the sector. Upon review, it has been decided that the fare cap imposed vide the aforesaid letter shall stand withdrawn with effect from 23rd March, 2026," the order said.

WITH AGENCY INPUTS

GOVT LACKS DIRECTION, STRATEGY: LOP

Rahul flags possible fuel price spike after upcoming state polls

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Congress leader Rahul Gandhi on Saturday accused the Modi government of lacking both direction and strategy necessary to manage the current economic situation facing the nation.

Gandhi also expressed concern that the government will raise the prices of petrol, diesel and LPG following the elections in West Bengal, Tamil Nadu, Assam, Kerala and the UT of Puducherry scheduled next month.

The leader of opposition in Lok Sabha said the weakening value of rupee against the US dollar and a sharp rise in industrial fuel prices will inevitably lead to price hikes affecting every Indian.

He also claimed that while the government offers “empty rhetoric” and maintains that everything is “normal”, the reality is that the rising costs of daily items will impact every household.

“The rupee weakening against the dollar and heading towards 100, along with a sharp rise in industrial fuel prices – these are not just numbers; they are clear signals of the inflation to come.

“The government may call it normal, but the reality is: Production and transport will become more expensive; MSMEs will be hit the hardest; prices of everyday items will go up; and FII money will flow out even faster, putting more pressure on the stock market,” Gandhi said in a post in Hindi on X.

In other words, he said, it is certain to have a direct and deep impact on every family’s pocket.

“And it’s just a matter of time – after the elections, the prices of petrol, diesel and LPG will be hiked too,” Gandhi claimed.



PM Modi’s competence protected India from global crisis: Rajnath

HALDWANI: Defence Minister Rajnath Singh on Saturday credited Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s competence and foresight for “safeguarding” India from the ripple effects of global instability, asserting that the country has remained secure despite the escalating conflict in West Asia.

Speaking at an event here on the completion of four years of the Pushkar Singh Dhami-led government’s second term in Uttarakhand, the defence minister backed the prime minister’s stance that “war is not a solution” and called for a resolution through dialogue and diplomacy.

“The world is passing through a period of crisis. The continuous attacks in West Asia are a matter of concern for the global community. Our prime minister has clearly stated that a

“The Modi government has neither direction nor strategy – just empty rhetoric. The question is not what the government is saying, it is what is left on your plate,” he claimed.

resolution will only emerge through dialogue and diplomacy,” Singh said in a post on X in Hindi.

“When the world is at war, no country can remain unaffected. India may also be impacted during such times, but our prime minister, through his competence, capability and foresight, has ensured that the country does not get trapped in these crisis,” he said.

Singh noted that the ongoing attacks in West Asia are a matter of concern for the global community. “The efforts being made by Modi ji at a global level to resolve this crisis deserve full support,” he added.

While addressing the event, Singh lauded the Uttarakhand government for becoming the first in the country to implement the Uniform Civil Code (UCC).

The Congress has been critical of the government’s efforts to tackle the current situation arising out of the conflict in West Asia, which has affected India’s energy requirements.

STATESMAN ENTRY NO RESCUE FOR UNI

Centre takes over Rafi Marg plot post Del HC nod

SOUMYADIP MULLICK

KOLKATA: The Central government has taken possession of the Rafi Marg premises allotted to United News of India (UNI), hours after the Delhi High Court upheld the cancellation of the allotment over a four-decade failure to build the mandated media complex, and directed authorities to reclaim the land immediately.

Dismissing UNI’s plea, Justice Sachin Datta held that the cancellation was “fully justified and legally inevitable,” noting that the core purpose of the allotment — construction of a composite office complex for multiple media organisations — had remained unfulfilled since 1979.

The bench emphasised that public land allotted for a specific purpose cannot be “held hostage” by a defaulting allottee.

The court also took note of UNI’s request to commercially lease out up to 70% of the proposed building to generate funds, observing that such

CLOSER LOOK

- » The bench emphasised that public land allotted for a specific purpose cannot be ‘held hostage’ by a defaulting allottee
- » The land parcel, measuring about 5,289.52 sq metres in a prime central Delhi location, carries an indicative value of over Rs 400 crore
- » UNI had also undergone insolvency proceedings, with a resolution plan approved in favour of The Statesman Limited, though the court held that subsequent developments could not justify decades of default

a proposal ran contrary to the institutional purpose of the allotment, which envisaged a composite office complex for multiple media organisations, including the Press Council of India, a co-allottee.

Following the ruling, the Land and Development Office (L&DO), Ministry of Housing & Urban Affairs, took control of the property in compliance with the court’s direction to ensure lawful use of the land.

The land parcel, measuring about 5,289.52 sq metres in a prime central Delhi location, carries an indicative value of

over Rs 400 crore.

The court found that UNI failed to construct the building within the stipulated period, did not execute agreements with co-allottees and took no concrete steps towards development. It also recorded that the agency had expressed its inability to participate in the project due to financial constraints.

UNI had also undergone insolvency proceedings, with a resolution plan approved in favour of The Statesman Limited, though the court held that subsequent developments

could not justify decades of default.

A show-cause notice issued in January 2023 was followed by an inadequate response, leading to the cancellation of allotment in March that year.

Rejecting UNI’s argument on delays due to lack of clarity over construction modalities or involvement of agencies such as CPWD and NBCC, the court said the record reflected prolonged inaction and persistent non-compliance.

The court clarified that it had not adjudicated upon the rights of the Press Council of India, a co-allottee.

The land at 9, Rafi Marg was allotted to UNI in 1979 for constructing a composite office complex for multiple media organisations, with a condition requiring construction within a fixed timeframe.

Measuring about 5,289.52 sq metres, the land is estimated to have an indicative value of over Rs 400 crore at prevailing rates.

Despite revisions and opportunities given by the

Centre over the years, including in 1986, 1999 and 2000, no construction was undertaken. UNI failed to finalise building plans, execute agreements with co-allottees or take steps towards development, reflecting persistent inaction.

In 2022, UNI admitted financial incapacity and expressed its inability to participate in the project. It also failed to cooperate with co-allottees such as the Press Council of India, did not vacate portions of land required for joint development and avoided coordination efforts.

Authorities also flagged misuse of the land, including running a canteen and a proposal to lease out up to 70% of the proposed building, contrary to the institutional purpose. Official sources also claimed that no ground rent had been paid for decades.

Following a show cause notice in January 2023 and an unsatisfactory reply, the allotment was cancelled in March 2023 — a decision now upheld by the High Court.

Haryana CM calls for deeper ties with Africa



NEW DELHI: Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini on Saturday said Haryana is keen to deepen ties with African nations, highlighting strong potential for collaboration in agriculture and allied sectors. Addressing the India–Africa Strategic Partnership session at the Bharat Electricity Summit–2026, he said cooperation in modern technology, improved seeds, irrigation, dairy development and agro-based industries can benefit both sides.

He stressed that Haryana’s engagement with Africa

goes beyond “business to business” and reflects a “heart to heart” partnership rooted in shared growth. He said the state government is committed to promoting institutional collaboration, investment and knowledge exchange with African nations.

The event was chaired by Union minister Manohar Lal Khattar, with MoS Shripad Yesso Naik also addressing delegates. Saini expressed confidence that enhanced ties will open new avenues for economic growth in the coming years.

ASHWANI SHARMA

SHIMLA: Slashing the state’s budget outlay significantly, in view of the serious fiscal crisis and the Centre’s withdrawal of the Revenue Deficit Grant (RDG), Chief Minister Sukhinder Singh Sukhu presented a Rs 54,928 cr budget for the year 2026-27.

The size of the budget has decreased by Rs 3,586 crore this year compared to Rs 58,514 crore in the previous financial year. However, what marks the biggest highlight of Sukhu’s fourth budget is his announcement to defer 50 percent of the Chief Minister’s salary and equally a similar cut on the salaries of the Deputy Chief Minister and ministers up to 30 percent, along with the state’s top bureaucracy, including the Chief Secretary, DGP and Principal Chief Conservator of Forests.

“As part of a policy of ‘fiscal discipline’, a portion of the salaries of individuals ranging from the chief minister, ministers, and MLAs to senior officials will be temporarily deferred for the next six months. Additionally, 20% of the salaries of all chairpersons, vice-chairpersons, and deputy chairpersons of various corporations and boards will remain deferred for the same period,” Sukhu said in his budget speech.

Yet he announced that no such cut will be imposed on Class III and Class IV employees, who will receive their full salaries, and there has been no reduction in the pensions of retirees.

The Congress MLAs will forego 20% of their salaries, and Speaker Kuldeep Pathania has also voluntarily opted



to be included in this list. For secretaries, this reduction will amount to 20%.

He said the boards, corporations, PSUs, autonomous bodies, universities, and institutions receiving grants or budgetary assistance from the government are expected to implement this decision in alignment with the government’s directive.

Conveying his respect for the constitutional dignity and independence of the judiciary, the Chief Minister hoped that the High Court would provide guidance and accord its consent to the temporary deferment of 20% of salaries at the level of district and additional district judges and 3% for the Group A and B officials within judicial institutions.

Sukhu has urged the judiciary to consider, at its discretion, deferring up to 30% of salaries voluntarily at the senior levels. “I, however, want to make it clear that this is only a temporary deferment, and as soon as the financial condition of the state improves, the amount will be returned,” he said. The decision, he said, was necessitated by the state’s economic condition and to ensure that everyone continues to receive their salaries and

pensions and that development works are also carried out without disruptions.

But, during the budget presentation, the House witnessed commotion, sloganeering, and protests by the opposition BJP, which protested against certain remarks of the Chief Minister when he was trying to explain how the RDG crisis has put the state in a tight spot.

Here, he claimed that it was a matter of sorrow and concern that the opposition BJP did not help the state government. The opposition, rather, abandoned the state in its difficult time and did not stand with the people of the state, who he said would never forgive the BJP.

Due to BJP protests, and MLAs led by Jairam Thakur, Leader of the Opposition (LoP), the House was adjourned for a while, and later efforts were made to restore order and help the Chief Minister to read out his 111-page speech, which he completed in four hours—the longest one in the history.

Eventually, the Speaker agreed to get the objectionable words removed from the proceedings and also the text of the Chief Minister’s speech.

Sukhu admitted that discontinuation of the RDG has impacted the annual budget.

SPECIAL ASSEMBLY SESSION ON APRIL 13

Punjab to amend anti-sacrilege law for ‘stricter punishment’

CHANDIGARH: Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann on Saturday said his government will convene a special session of the Assembly on April 13 to amend a 2008 Act to impose stricter punishment for sacrilege of Guru Granth Sahib and other religious texts.

The proposed legislation will include heavy fines, property confiscation and cover offences committed through digital content, with the draft being prepared in consultation with the “sant samaj and legal experts”, Mann said in a statement.

Asserting its “zero-tolerance” stance, the government

said no one guilty of ‘beadbi’ (sacrilege) will be spared. During a meeting with religious leaders in Amritsar, Mann said, “The session will be convened on the occasion of Khalsa Sajna Diwas (on April 13) and the Act will be formed in consultation with Sant Samaj (religious leaders) and legal experts.”

Opinions from eminent lawyers across the country will be sought while preparing the draft of this legislation to ensure exemplary punishment for perpetrators of this heinous crime, he said.

Mann said that during the session, necessary amendments

will be made to the Jagt Jyot Sri Guru Granth Sahib Satkar Act, 2008, enacted by the Punjab Government, to introduce a strong and comprehensive law to prevent ‘beadbi’ of Sri Guru Granth Sahib and other religious texts.

Inviting leaders of various sects, Takshals, Nihang Singh groups, Udasi sects, Nirmala sects, Kar Seva groups, Ragis, and Kathavachaks, the CM urged them to attend the special session and witness the passage of this historic legislation.

Speaker Kultar Singh Sandhwan and MLA Inderbir Singh Nijjar will soon visit Samana to persuade activist Gurjeet Singh

Khalsa to end his protest and invite him to attend the special assembly session as well.

Khalsa has been sitting atop a nearly 400-foot telecom tower in Samana since October 12, 2024, demanding stringent punishment for sacrilege incidents. “The Punjab government respects the sentiments of Sant Samaj and devotees and is committed to enacting a strict law that will deter any mischievous elements from committing acts of ‘beadbi,’” said Mann.

Mann also said the law will include stringent punishments, heavy fines, and even confiscation of the property of the accused. “The new act will also

cover the ‘beadbi’ carried out through digital content. The Punjab government is working with full sincerity to prevent incidents of ‘beadbi’ of religious texts,” he said.

Mann stressed that his government respects the religious sentiments of everyone and no one guilty of ‘beadbi’ will be spared.

Earlier, the delegation demanded that pending cases be expedited to ensure strict punishment for the guilty. They also expressed gratitude to the government for organising events commemorating the 350th Shaheedi Diwas of Sri Guru Tegh Bahadur.

MP, Raj natural economic partners, says CM Yadav, woos Jaipur investors

CM highlights reforms, incentives, river-link project to draw Raj investors

SATYAPRAKASH SHARMA

NEW DELHI: Madhya Pradesh Chief Minister Mohan Yadav on Saturday described MP and Rajasthan as “twin states” with deep cultural, social and emerging economic linkages, urging investors in Jaipur to explore expanding their footprint in MP.

Addressing an interactive session on “Investment Opportunities in Madhya Pradesh”, Yadav said the two states complement each other economically—Rajasthan’s strength in textiles and gems and jewellery, combined with MP’s organic cotton production, textile parks and robust manufacturing ecosystem, can create a strong value chain.

Highlighting infrastructure collaboration, he said work is progressing rapidly on the Parvati-Kalinsindh-Chambal river interlinking project. “This project will transform the region’s future,” he said, adding that traditional “roti-beti” ties between the states are now



being strengthened by water-sharing cooperation.

Pitching MP as an emerging investment hub, the Chief Minister said the state has rolled out 26 new industrial policies and is working on policies for emerging sectors like space and artificial intelligence. He underlined that MP is a power-surplus state and is positioning itself as a “green, clean and solar energy capital,” offering competitive electricity tariffs.

Yadav said the government has earmarked Rs 6,104 crore for industrial promotion and Rs 1 lakh crore for infrastructure development, while

its single-window clearance system—Invest MP 3.0—has streamlined approvals. Incentives, including capital subsidies, are being extended across sectors such as textiles, tourism, healthcare and manufacturing.

He also highlighted initiatives in medical education, dairy development, mining and aviation, including viability gap funding for air services and expansion of helicopter connectivity to boost tourism.

Principal Secretary, Industrial Policy and Investment Promotion, Raghvendra Kumar Singh gave a presentation on investment opportunities in Madhya Pradesh.

“The state govt will provide full support at every step—from approvals to operations

— CM Mohan Yadav

MPIDC Managing Director Chandramouli Shukla was also present at the event.

Industry representatives noted that MP offers abundant land, improved ease of doing business and growing infrastructure, making it attractive for investors. Industry leaders shared positive experiences of investing in the state, particularly in renewable energy and manufacturing.

Yadav also held one-on-one meetings with industrialists, inviting them to invest in what he called the “heart of India,” promising policy support, incentives and a stable business environment.

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY
No. JHS/Comm/e-Auction/26/144 Date: 19.03.2026

E-Auction Notice

On Behalf of The President Of India, The Divisional Railway Manager, (Commercial) Jhansi invites e-auction as per categories given as under:-

Category: Parcel

Catalogue No.: JHS-LEASING-60

Asset Details: 01- Train number 12198 = 02 SLR-F-I & F-II, 02- Train number 12049 = 01 SLR-F-I, 03- Train number 12279 = 01 SLR-F-I, 04- Train number 22198 = 01 SLR-F-I, 05- Train number 22195 = 01 SLR-F-I, 06- Train number 11107 = 02 SLR-R-I & F-I, 07- Train number 22547 = 01 SLR-F-I, 08- Train number 11086 = 02 SLR-R-I & F-I.

Auction Start: 01.04.2026 at 11:00 hrs

Auction End: 01.04.2026 at 13:10 hrs

Note: Prospective bidders are requested to visit e-Auction Leasing module on IREPS website (www.ireps.gov.in). The Lot-wise details are available therein under the above mentioned Catalogue Number.

627/26 (ADM)

www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY
Tender Notice No. 11920252026 Date: 18.03.2026

E-Tender Notice

Divisional Railway Manager (Engineering) / North Central Railway / Prayagraj, for and on behalf of the President of India, invites E-TENDERS on prescribed form for the following work up to 13.30 hrs on 16.04.2026 The details of the Tender are as under:-

S. N. : 1

Tender No.: 263

Approx. Cost (₹) : 32,99,271.15

Name of Work: Preparation of DPR of 2 Lane ROB in lieu of Level crossings in CAR-CPU Section under Sr.DEN/I/PRYJ (7Nos.)

Bid Security (₹) : 66,000/-

Completion Period : 04 months

Eligibility Criteria for Similar work: NIL

S. N. : 2

Tender No.: 264

Approx. Cost (₹) : 2,72,10,166.16

Name of work: Through Sleeper Renewal (Primary) by contractor's PQRS in DDU-PRYJ section under Sr.DEN/I/PRYJ

Bid Security (₹) : 5,44,200/-

Completion Period : 06 Months

Eligibility Criteria for Similar work: "Any P. Way Work" Note:- With Special condition in Tender: Tenderer/ Bidder will submit an affidavit of ownership of minimum 02 Nos. of PQRS / SQRS / TLE machines for working in running track during traffic block and 02 Nos. of Gantry for working in PQRS depot.

Date of Opening of tender : 16.04.2026

1. Tender on line can be submitted up to 13.30 hrs. of tender opening date. 2. The complete information along with tender document of above E-Tenders are available on Website www.ireps.gov.in, up to 13:30 hrs. on the due date of tender opening.

629/26(DG)

www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 84 Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, 2023

Whereas complaint has been made before me that the accused namely **B.S. Paul, S/o. Kartar Singh, R/o.: H.No.72, D-Block, Preet Vihar, New Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in a case vide **FIR No.275/2017, U/S 33/38 Delhi Excise Act** registered at **P.S Fatehpur Beri, South District, New Delhi** and it has been returned on a warrant of arrest thereupon issued stating that the said **B.S. Paul** could not be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that accused **B.S. Paul** is absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said **B.S. Paul**, accused of **FIR No. 275/2017, U/S 33/38 Delhi Excise Act, P.S. Fatehpur Beri, South District, New Delhi** is required to appear before the court to answer the said complaint on or before **28.04.2026**.

By Order, Ashish Kumar Meena

Judicial Magistrate First Class-01 (South)

Room No.214, Saket Court Complex, New Delhi

DP/3671/SD/2026 (Court Matter)

'DEADLIEST CRACKDOWN SINCE 1979'

'Wave of executions feared in Iran; three young men already hanged'

BEIRUT: A 19-year-old star wrestler and two other young men were hanged in Iran this week, raising alarm among rights groups that a wave of executions may be underway as authorities facing relentless attacks from the US and Israel seek to squelch public dissent.

The three men are the first to be executed from among the tens of thousands who were arrested during a January crackdown on nationwide protests. Rights groups say more than 100 others could face death sentences.

The wrestler, Saleh Mohammadi, was hanged early Thursday morning — along with Mehdi Qasemi and Saeed Davoudi — in Qom, just south of the capital, Tehran, according to state media. They had been sentenced on charges of “moharabeh,” or “waging war against God” for allegedly killing two police officers during protests in the city.

Amnesty International said the convictions of the three, and of others arrested during the protests, came in “grossly unfair trials” that used confessions extracted by torture.



Iranians attend an anti-government protest in Tehran, Jan 9, 2026 AP

The executions were “intended to instill fear in society and deter new protests,” amid the U.S.-Israeli war on Iran, said Mahmood Amiry-Moghaddam, director of Iran Human Rights, an Oslo-based group that has documented detentions.

Amiry-Moghaddam said he worries many more “executions of protesters and political prisoners may be imminent.”

He said his group has documented at least 27 death sentences that have been issued against people arrested during the protests. Another 100 face

charges that carry the death penalty, and Iranian state media have aired hundreds of forced confessions to crimes punishable by death, he said.

Nationwide protests that began in late December peaked in the first week of January, prompting the deadliest crackdown by Iranian security forces since the Islamic Republic took power in 1979.

A complete death toll has been hard to gauge because of internet restrictions by authorities. The US-based Human Rights Activists New Agency,

INSIGHT

» Rights groups say more than 100 others could face death sentences

» At the height of the protests, authorities signaled that fast trials & executions lay ahead

which relies on a network of contacts inside Iran, said it confirmed that more than 7,000 were killed and that it was investigating thousands more. It said over 50,000 were arrested in just over six weeks. The government acknowledged more than 3,000 were killed. At the height of the protests, Iranian authorities signaled that fast trials and executions lay ahead.

At the time, US President Donald Trump suggested military action might be an option to stop the deadly crackdown. But he soon announced that he learned that plans for executions were halted, signaling that a military operation was no longer on the table.

Just a month later, Israel and the US launched an intense air-strike campaign against Iran, pounding military installations and targeting the top political and security leadership of Iran. The security agencies believed to be responsible for the deadly crackdown on protesters are also being targeted.

Despite the war, Iranian authorities have kept up the crackdown on dissent. Authorities say scores have been detained since the war began on Feb. 28, including some who took part in the January protests. Because of Iran's internet blackout, there have been scant details about the three men executed Thursday. Amiry-Moghaddam said Davoudi was born on March 20, 2004, meaning he was executed a day before his 22nd birthday. Qasemi's age was not known, he said.

Mohammadi appeared to be a standout in wrestling, a sport that is wildly popular in Iran. In 2024, he won a bronze medal at an international youth freestyle wrestling tournament in the Russian city of Krasnoyarsk.

AGENCIES

UKRAINE SEEKS TO MOVE FORWARD PEACE TALKS

At least 2 killed in Russian strike in Zaporizhzhia region

KYIV: A Russian drone attack on the city of Zaporizhzhia killed at least two people on Saturday, a Ukrainian official said, ahead of expected US-Ukraine talks.

Zaporizhzhia regional head Ivan Fedorov said a man and a woman were killed and two children wounded when a Russian drone hit a private house in the morning.

The attack came ahead of the expected US-Ukraine talks, which Ukrainian state media reported would take place later in the day in Miami.

Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said late Thursday he had sent an official delegation to the United States in a bid to move forward suspended US-brokered talks on ending Russia's invasion.

Trilateral talks involving Russia, which have yet to produce any breakthrough on key issues, have been on ice while the Iran war has dominated international attention.

The White House did not confirm any meeting with the Ukrainian delegation.

Zelenskyy said the main tasks in the US will be to ensure

HIGHLIGHTS

» Zaporizhzhia regional head Ivan Fedorov said a man and a woman were killed and two children wounded when a Russian drone hit a private house

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» Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said late Thursday he had sent an official delegation to the US in a bid to move forward suspended US-brokered peace talks

» Trilateral talks involving Russia, which have yet to produce any breakthrough, have been on ice while the Iran war has dominated international attention

that the trilateral talks resume and that Washington continues to allow other NATO countries to purchase American weapons to send to Ukraine.

A senior Kremlin official indicated Friday that a new round of US-mediated negotiations between Moscow and Kyiv will likely take place soon.

“The pause is temporary; we hope it's temporary regarding the continuation of the trilateral format,” said Kremlin spokesman Dmitry Peskov.

Western European officials have over the past year repeatedly accused Russian President Vladimir Putin of dragging his feet in negotiations while he tries to press his bigger army's battlefield initiative and capture more Ukrainian land. Russian forces hold nearly 20 per cent of Ukraine.

The latest conflict in the Middle East that began February 28 with Israeli and US strikes on Iran has diverted international attention from Ukraine's plight.

AGENCIES

Lebanon: Israel strikes Hezbollah's civilian as well as military wings

BEIRUT: An Israeli strike on a health center in southern Lebanon instantly killed 12 medical workers, seriously wounded one and left four missing under the rubble for hours.

The March 13 strike in the village of Burj Qalaouiyyah, one of the single deadliest strikes in Lebanon since the latest Israel-Hezbollah war began on March 2, targeted a center run by Hezbollah's health arm, the Islamic Health Society, which has so far lost 24 members over the past two weeks.

Since the latest war began, Israel's military has not only been targeting the group's military assets but also its civilian institutions in an apparent attempt to weaken the Iran-



Smoke rises from Israeli airstrikes that struck a building housing Al-Manar channel studios in Dahiyeh on March 3 AP

backed group further and try to push its supporters away from it.

Hezbollah is a political party as well as an armed group, and its health and social service institutions have helped strengthen

its base of support over the years.

In addition to health centers, Israel has destroyed more than a dozen branches of Hezbollah's financial arm, al-Qard al-Hasan. Other strikes heavily damaged

Hezbollah's Al-Manar TV headquarters and its Al-Nour radio stations.

The strikes also have targeted the group's Amana gas stations and discount shops known as Sajjad, where low-income people can buy highly subsidized products.

On Wednesday, an Israeli airstrike on an apartment in central Beirut killed Mohammed Sherri, the head of political programs at Hezbollah's Al-Manar TV, along with his wife. Israel has accused Hezbollah of using health facilities for military purposes and has said al-Qard al-Hasan — officially a charitable organization that provides interest-free loans — finances the group's military activities.

AGENCIES

Cuba rejects US Embassy's request to import diesel for its generators

WASHINGTON: The Cuban government has refused a request by the US Embassy in Havana to allow it to import diesel for its generators while the Trump administration continues to impose a fuel blockade on the island, according to two US officials familiar with the matter.

The Cuban government turned down the request as the US State Department has been weighing a reduction in staffing at the embassy in Havana because of the lack of diesel. Such a move would likely lead to a US demand for a similar reduction in staffing at the Cuban Embassy in Washington, say the officials, who spoke on condition of anonymity to discuss the sensitive matter.

The Cuban government rejection was first reported by

The standoff on diesel comes as Trump has been pressing for dramatic change in government led by Cuban President Miguel Díaz-Canel

The Washington Post.

Cuba has struggled with dwindling oil since the US removed Venezuela's leader, halting critical petroleum shipments from the nation. President Donald Trump then threatened tariffs on any country selling or supplying Cuba with oil.

The island is relying on its own natural gas, solar power and its own oil to run thermo-

electric plants, but that hasn't been enough to meet demand.

The standoff on diesel comes as Trump has been pressing for dramatic change in government led by Cuban President Miguel Díaz-Canel.

Trump has suggested that top Cuban leaders would be smart to avoid the fate of former Venezuelan President Nicolás Maduro, who was ousted and arrested in a US military operation in January. Venezuela had been Cuba's closest ally and provided it with heavily subsidized oil.

Any potential staffing reduction at the embassy is not expected to come immediately because the US believes it has enough diesel in reserve to last for another month, according to one official.

AGENCIES

CAUGHT OFF GUARD

Surprise, embarrassment, unease in Japan after Trump invokes Pearl Harbor to defend Iran war

TOKYO: Senior US and Japanese officials tend to shy away from anything but very careful public comments about Japan's 1941 sneak attack on US forces at Pearl Harbor.

So there was embarrassment, confusion and unease on Saturday in Japan after President Donald Trump casually used the World War II attack to justify his secrecy before launching the war against Iran.

The Japanese discomfort was compounded by the fact that country's Prime Minister Sanae Takaichi was sitting awkwardly at Trump's side as he spoke.

Partly, the reaction is linked to the crucial security and economic role that the US plays for Japan, its top ally in the region. Put simply, Japan needs to make sure the US relationship thrives. That's why Takaichi was in Washington.



FILE PIC

KEY POINTS

» The Japan's discomfort was compounded by the fact that country's Prime Minister Sanae Takaichi was sitting awkwardly at Trump's side as he spoke

» Senior leaders, including Takaichi, have argued that Japan has apologised enough for what happened in the war

But it's also a reflection of just how fresh the political debate about Japan's role in World War II remains here, even 80 years after its end.

Senior leaders, including Takaichi, have argued that Japan has apologised enough for what happened in the war. Takaichi herself has recently hinted at visiting Tokyo's controversial Yasukuni Shrine, where Japanese war criminals are honoured among the 2.5 million war dead.

It is, however, somewhat startling for Japan to see these history questions spill over into a White House summit.

On Friday, when asked by a Japanese reporter why he didn't tell allies in Europe and Asia ahead of the US attack on Iran, Trump cited Pearl Harbor to defend his decision, saying, “Who knows better about surprise than Japan? Why didn't you tell me about Pearl Harbor, OK?”

The liberal leaning Asahi

newspaper said in an editorial Saturday that Trump's comments “should not be overlooked.”

“Making such a remark to justify a sneak attack and boast about its outcome is a piece of nonsense that ignores lessons from history,” Asahi said.

Social media reaction has ranged from accusations of ignorance and rudeness by the US president to claims that he didn't see Japan as an equal partner.

AGENCIES

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 84 BNSS

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused Person **Tinku, S/o:** Ashok Dass, **R/o:** C-22/32, Shahbad Dairy, **Delhi**, has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No. 280/2020, Dt. 19.06.2020 U/S: 33 Delhi Excise Act, PS: Shahbad Dairy, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused person(s) **Tinku**, cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused person(s) **Tinku**, has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused person **Tinku**, of **FIR No. 280/2020, Dt. 19.06.2020 U/S: 33 Delhi Excise Act, PS: Shahbad Dairy, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **22.04.2026**.

By Order
Bharti Beniwal
Judicial Magistrate First Class-05, (North)
Court Room No. 114, 1st Floor
Rohini Court, Delhi
DP/3476/ON/2026
(Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 84 Bhartiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, 2023

Whereas complaint has been made before me that the accused person Namely **Shah Alam S/o** Sh. Ashfaq **R/o** Ujhari, Mohalla Jawaipura, Amroha, U.P. & E-49/D-59, Mazdoor Janta Colony, Babarpur, Delhi-54 has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR/CC No. 430/2020 U/s 429/34 IPC PS: Timarpur, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Shah Alam** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Shah Alam** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Shah Alam** accused of **FIR/CC No. 430/2020 U/s 429/34 IPC PS: Timarpur, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **11.05.2026**.

By Order
Sh. Karanbir Singh
JMF-02, Room No. 26
Tis Hazari Courts, Delhi
DP/3619/N/2026
(Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr. P.C.

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused Person **Kamal, S/o:** Lt. Om Parkash, **R/o:** 264 Chandra Shekhar Gali Babarpur, **Delhi**, has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No. 314/19, U/S: 33/58 Delhi Ex. Act, PS: Gokul Puri, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused person(s) **Kamal**, cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused person(s) **Kamal**, has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused person **Kamal**, of **FIR No. 314/19, U/S: 33/58 Delhi Ex. Act, PS: Gokul Puri, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **22.04.2026**.

By Order
Ms. Shruti Saraswat
Ld Judicial Magistrate First Class
North/East District
Karkardooma court, Delhi
DP/3636/NE/2026
(Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF A PERSON ACCUSED

(See Section 82 Cr. PC/ (84-Bhartiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, 2023)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person namely **Mohd Sarfaraj @ Babu S/o Mohd Moti R/o Jhuggi C-356, JJ Colony Bawana, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 135/2023 U/s 420/34 IPC at P.S. Sarai Rohilla, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Mohd Sarfaraj @ Babu** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Mohd Sarfaraj @ Babu** have absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Mohd Sarfaraj @ Babu** of **FIR No. 135/2023 U/s 420/34 IPC at P.S.: Sarai Rohila, Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **21.04.2026**.

By Order
Rangat Ghirra
Judicial Magistrate First Class-04
Central District, Room No. 37,
Tis Hazari Courts, Delhi
DP/3727/N/2026

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY

Tender Notice No. 78-Elect/G/PRYJ/25-26 Dt. 19.03.2026

Tender Notice

Senior Divl. Electrical Engineer/Gen/N.C. Rly/Prayagraj, for and on behalf of the President of India, invite the following e-Tenders on prescribed form for the following works up to **15.00 hrs. on 10.04.2026**. The details of the tenders are as under:-

SN. 1. Tender Notice: ELG-157-2526

Name of work: Electrical work in connection with the work of "05 HBD Lite systems in TDL, SKB, CPA, ETW and ALJN over PRYJ division." & Electrical work in connection with extension of Construction of BLC monitoring center at 1st Floor of existing Monitoring Building & Tundla.

Cost of work: 2419090.29 **Bid Security:** 48400.00

Duration of completion: 06 Months

SN. 2. Tender Notice: ELG-158-2526

Name of work: Re-wiring of staff quarters under section of SSE/PS/MZP, SBDR, ETW, FTP, DER & MKP

Cost of work: 21509492.67 **Bid Security:** 257600.00

Duration of completion: 06 Months

Tender Opening Date: 10.04.2026, 15.00 hrs., Note- 1. The complete information along with tender document of above e-Tender is available on Website **www.ireps.gov.in** up to 15.00 hrs. on the due date of tender opening.

634/26 FA

North central railways @CPRONCR www.nccr.indianrailways.gov.in

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

(SEE SECTION 82(2) (ii) Cr.P.C./84 BNSS)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person(s) **Gaurav Sonkar S/o Motilal R/o Flat No. 182-B, LIG Pocket-E, GTB Enclave, Shahdara, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 256/2018, U/s 307/325/506 IPC Act, PS GTB Enclave, Delhi** and it has been returned to a Warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused person(s) **Gaurav Sonkar** can not be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused person(s) **Gaurav Sonkar** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused person(s) **Gaurav Sonkar** of case **FIR No. 256/2018, U/s 307/325/506 IPC Act, PS GTB Enclave, Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before dated **25.05.2026**.

By Order
Kumar Rajat
Additional Sessions Judge-07
Room No. 61, 3r Floor
Karkardooma Courts, Delhi
DP/3516/SHD/2026
(Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82(2) Cr. P.C./84 Bhartiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita
Whereas a complaint has been made before me that the accused person namely **Manju W/o Deepak R/o** House Near Pole No. 26A, Ground Floor, Village Badu Sarai, New Delhi have committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence under **CT No. 271/2024 U/s 135 I.E. Act.**, has been registered at **P.S. Chhawla, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest there upon issued that the said, **Manju** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said, **Manju** has absconded (or is concealing herself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused, **Manju** of under **CT No. 271/2024 U/s 135 I.E. Act.**, has been registered at **P.S. Chhawla, Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **24.04.2026**.

By Order
Ms. Harleen Singh
ADSJ, Special Court Electricity Court
Room No. 609, Dwarka Courts, New Delhi
DP/3226/DW/2026
(Court Notice)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 84 Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, 2023

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Kaji Shabbir @ Shabbir @ Sonu @ Mehroof Khan @ Milan @ Robin, S/o: Qazi Hamid, R/o: Vagabond, Footpath near Nizamuddin Dargah, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 77/2025 U/s 305(2) / 317(2), Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, 2023, P.S.: Hazrat Nizamuddin, New Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Kaji Shabbir @ Shabbir @ Sonu @ Mehroof Khan @ Milan @ Robin** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Kaji Shabbir @ Shabbir @ Sonu @ Mehroof Khan @ Milan @ Robin** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Kaji Shabbir @ Shabbir @ Sonu @ Mehroof Khan @ Milan @ Robin** accused of offence in case **FIR No. 77/2025 U/s 305(2) / 317(2), Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, 2023 P.S.: Hazrat Nizamuddin, New Delhi** and is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **23.04.2026**.

By Order
Ms. Manuj Kaushal
Judicial Magistrate First Class-03
Room No. 512, Saket Court, New Delhi
DP/3605/SE/2026
(Court Matter)

Time to rise and shine

‘Switch on’: Kohli fires up RCB, urges team to go hard in training sessions

BENGALURU: Talismanic batter Virat Kohli on Saturday urged his Royal Challengers Bengaluru teammates to “switch on” themselves and not waste even a minute at the training sessions as they gear up for their IPL title defence.

Addressing the squad during their first practice session at the M Chinnaswamy Stadium, Kohli underlined the need to maintain the intensity that brought them the title last year.

“We worked really hard over the last two to three seasons to achieve what we did last year, and it’s only going to get tougher because other teams are going to come hard at us,” Kohli said.

RCB will open their IPL 2026 campaign against Sunrisers Hyderabad on March 28 at the M Chinnaswamy Stadium. Emphasising urgency from day one, he added, “We don’t waste these days. We stay ahead. So, switch on now. Let’s not waste even a minute of any session that we are a part of. We must give our 120 per cent for these two and a half months.”

RCB added Venkatesh Iyer, Mangesh Yadav, Jordan Cox, Vicky Ostwal and Satvik



Royal Challengers' Virat Kohli bats at nets during a training session

FILE

Deswal to their squad at the auction.

Head coach Andy Flower expressed satisfaction with the squad assembled after the auction, saying the franchise had strengthened key areas.

“We had an interesting auction and I think we’ve improved our squad, to be quite frank. We’ve brought in some great new additions. Integrating them into the RCB way alongside established play-

ers led by Virat and Rajat is an exciting part of building this team,” Flower said.

Highlighting the significance of being reigning champions, Flower said the team would embrace the challenge rather than dwell on past success.

“There is one difference this year, we’ve got a star on our shirt. That’s a very proud feeling for all RCB fans. But that season is gone. Now we have

a new challenge ahead, and it’s an exciting one. We’re here to win this year’s IPL,” he added.

Wicketkeeper-batter Jitesh Sharma spoke about the positive atmosphere within the group as new and old members came together.

“Everyone was very excited to meet each other. I was excited to get more batting time. I got a chance to meet all the coaches and train again,” he said. AGENCIES

Akash Deep out of IPL

KOLKATA: Kolkata Knight Riders suffered yet another blow to their pace resources with India seamer Akash Deep ruled out for at least eight weeks due to a stress reaction in lower back on Saturday, which effectively sidelined him from the Indian Premier League.

The injury has also put the right-arm pacer in serious doubt for the one-off Test against Afghanistan in early June. “Akash Deep has had stress reaction on his lower back. There has been recurrence and it might take 8-12 weeks to heal. He is not going to play the IPL and is very unlikely to be selected against Afghanistan,” a BCCI source said.

The 29-year-old Bengal pacer had looked short of full fitness, bowling just 13 overs in the first innings and under seven in the second. AGENCIES

Asian Cup: Triple delight for Japan as Hamano breaks Oz hearts in final

SYDNEY: Maika Hamano took a pass from the left with her back to goal, turned and launched a powerful strike from outside the area in a moment of individual brilliance that secured Japan a third Women’s Asian Cup final with a 1-0 win over Australia.

The 21-year-old Hamano, on loan at Tottenham from Chelsea, scored in the 17th minute to almost silence the crowd of 74,397 at Sydney’s Stadium Australia on Saturday night.

The Australians applied all the pressure in the last 10 minutes pressing for an equalizer but were continually denied by Japan’s defense, including Alanna Kennedy’s close-range header with two minutes left in regulation. Japan had beaten Australia in finals to win back-to-back Women’s Asian Cups in 2014 and 2018 and have now won the title three times in the last four continental championships. “I just want to enjoy it today because it’s only the third time that Japan actually managed to win this tournament,” Japan coach Nils Nielsen said. “(We) really deserve it, I mean we won six games — it’s OK we take the trophy. The girls fought with everything they had, so



Maika Hamano's strike proved to be the difference

AP

29

Japan tallied 29 goals and conceded just one in six games in a dominant performance

The Australians, who reached the semifinals of the Women’s World Cup on home soil in 2023, had 54% of possession, had 14 shots on goal compared to nine for Japan, and considerably more passes, crosses and touches in the opposition box.

But as captain Sam Kerr said, “They beat us just off one moment. For most of the game, we had the better chances and definitely in the second half, most of the possession. So it was just one moment. Unfortunately, that’s what football is decided on. AGENCIES

FEAR FACTOR GONE: ASHWIN

Knight Riders’ bowling devoid of X-factor?

CHENNAI: Kolkata Knight Riders’ bowling attack no longer carries the same aura of fear and the “novelty factor” around their mystery spinners have faded, says former India off-spinner Ravichandran Ashwin.

Analysing the strength and weakness of KKR ahead of the IPL, Ashwin said India spinner Varun Chakravarthy will have a lot of responsibility on his shoulders. “I don’t think oppositions will be worried after looking at KKR’s bowling attack. I think the mystery factory, the novelty factor, and the fear, that particular facet, would have gone. Earlier, batters used to go to the analyst’s room, watch the bowler’s hand, or just look to take a single,” Ashwin said. “Varun is at a stage in his career where he has to find answers. But, it is natural for every cricketer’s progress and his career. I think the novelty factor is out,” he said.

Ashwin also noted that seasoned all-rounder Sunil Narine’s effectiveness has diminished, particularly with restrictions on his variations.

“Sunil Narine also cannot bowl the faster ball anymore,



I think the mystery factory, the novelty factor, and the fear, that particular facet, would have gone

— Ravichandran Ashwin

because of his action. Eden Gardens is a small ground, so now it becomes easy for the opposition to say, ‘Hey, you know what, here is a team that is not going to make me scared, so let us go after them,’ AGENCIES

Liverpool lose to Brighton, Fernandes shines in draw

LONDON: Liverpool’s troubles in the Premier League intensified with a 2-1 loss at Brighton on Saturday, leaving the stuttering defending champions on a three-match winless run and under threat of dropping out of the Champions League qualification spots.

Danny Welbeck scored twice for Brighton at Amex Stadium, either side of Milos Kerkez’s equalizer for Liverpool in its latest disjointed display under manager Arne Slot.

To add to Liverpool’s woes, striker Hugo Ekitike hobbled off in the eighth minute with a left leg problem and joined an injury list that also includes Mohamed Salah and Alisson Becker, who got hurt this week.

Bruno Fernandes got a goal and an assist and Harry Maguire marked his return to the England squad by getting a red card as Manchester United drew 2-2 at Bournemouth in the Premier League on Friday.

After a dull first half, Fernandes, so often United’s saviour, put the visitor ahead from the penalty spot an hour in. AGENCIES

The Way Forward Sometimes Begins with a U-Turn



Madhukar

File Your Updated Income Tax Return (ITR-U) before

31st
March, 2026

Income tax Department receives information relating to financial transactions from various sources like banks, SROs, financial institutions, foreign jurisdictions, charitable organisations, commercial establishments and Law Enforcement Agencies etc. The information is shared with taxpayers in AIS, e- verification and through SAKSHAM NUDGE campaigns.

Taxpayers are accordingly advised to see AIS, e-campaigns and SAKSHAM NUDGE messages related to unreported income or unsupported deductions / exemptions and review their ITR to correct if any income is not disclosed or unsupported claims have been made and file their updated ITR under section 139(8A) at specific rate. The time limit for filing an updated return is four years from the end of the relevant Assessment Year.

Key Features of an Updated Return:

- Purpose:** To promote voluntary compliance and reduce litigation.
- Form:** An updated return must be filed using Form ITR-U along with the applicable ITR form (ITR-1 To ITR-7) for the relevant assessment year.
- Additional Tax:** Filing an ITR-U requires the payment of additional tax, which varies based on the timing of the filing.
- Restrictions:** An Updated Return cannot be a return of loss, decrease the total tax liability, or result in increase of income tax refund.

Additional Tax Rates

The amount of additional tax (calculated on the aggregate of tax and interest payable) depends on when the return is filed:

ITR U - for the AY	Additional tax payable (if filed before 31.03.2026)
AY 2024-25	25% additional tax
AY 2023-24	50% additional tax
AY 2022-23	60% additional tax
AY 2021-22	70% additional tax

For more information and to pay income tax visit: www.incometax.gov.in



For Tutorial on ITR-U Scan QR code



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With over 17.4 crore voters and 824 constituencies at stake, the elections are not just about political power but also about governance models, voter eligibility controversies and the evolving nature of democracy

AUTHOR



DIPANKAR DEY

On March 15, the Election Commission of India (ECI) announced the schedule for Assembly elections in four States, Assam, Kerala, Tamil Nadu, West Bengal, and one Union Territory, Puducherry. The announcement sets in motion an electoral cycle that will determine governments across 824 constituencies. Some 17.4 crore people will vote across the five regions. Counting for all the constituencies is scheduled on May 4. Except in West Bengal, where elections will be conducted on two different dates (April 23 and 29), in all other regions, voters will cast their votes on April 9. In 2021, citing poor law and order conditions, the previous assembly election in West Bengal was held in eight phases. The Model Code of Conduct (MCC) came into force across the five regions the moment ECI made the announcement. In West Bengal, within 24 hours, the Election Commission transferred a large number of senior officials, including the chief secretary, home secretary, and director general of police.

SIR CONTROVERSY

In India, which is now considered an 'electoral autocracy', the upcoming elections are the second set of polls being held where the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) process has been completed, though ECI is yet to provide satisfactory explanations for the anomalies that arose

during the SIR. These include a lowered gender ratio in most States except Tamil Nadu and an abnormally high number of deletions compared to the estimated adult population. The deletions are expected to affect short-term migrants and married women in particular. According to the Hindu, it could affect West Bengal election results, where the 'Sword of Damocles' still hangs over 60 lakh people regarding their voting eligibility due to 'logical discrepancies' in their applications, which are still under review by judicial officers.

In West Bengal, as per the Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar, the total number of eligible voters stands at 6.44 crore, down from 7.04 crore in the electoral rolls published after the SIR on February 28. The drop is due to the removal of more than 64 lakh names identified as dead, duplicate, shifted, or absent during the verification process. The issue has triggered political reactions, with the Trinamool Congress, Left Front, and Congress urging the Election Commission of India to ensure that all genuine voters, including those under adjudication, are allowed to cast their votes. The BJP has not supported this demand and has instead defended the revision process.

In Tamil Nadu, the final electoral roll has 5.67 crore voters after deletion of 74 lakh entries. SIR deleted 8.57 lakh names in Kerala as per the final voters list, which has 2.69 crore voters.

SIR is not initiated in Assam. According to the final electoral rolls, Assam has approximately 2.25 crore voters. Incidentally, Assam was the first state in the country where the National Registrar of Citizens (NRC) exercise was rolled out for weeding out illegal immigrants. The NRC list, published on August 31, 2019, had found more than 31.1 million people eligible to be included in the registry while



VOTER ROLL QUESTIONS

West Bengal's electoral roll saw a drop of over 64 lakh names after revision—from 7.04 crore to 6.44 crore voters. Across states, deletions have run into tens of lakhs. Such large-scale revisions rarely occur this close to elections, making voter eligibility a central political and administrative flashpoint.



HIGH ECONOMIC STAKES

Tamil Nadu (₹31.19 lakh crore GSDP) and West Bengal (₹18.15 lakh crore) together account for a significant share of India's economic output. These elections are not just political—they directly influence industrial policy, MSME ecosystems, and welfare spending in two of India's most economically consequential states.

COMPETING DEVELOPMENT MODELS

These elections pit contrasting governance frameworks against each other. Tamil Nadu's welfare-driven Dravidian model, Kerala's human development approach, and West Bengal's decentralised schemes reflect distinct policy philosophies. Assam adds a strategic dimension, making the elections a broader referendum on development pathways, not just political power.

DID YOU KNOW?

WEST BENGLA houses 7.5 per cent of India's population on just 2.7 per cent of its land, making it one of the most densely populated states. Assam, with far lower density, reports disproportionately high crime rates against women—underscoring that governance challenges differ sharply across states beyond simple population metrics.

leaving out over 1.9 million people. This was conducted by the NRC co-ordinator, Prateek Hajela.

On May 20, the Assam NRC authority filed an FIR against its former NRC Co-ordinator Prateek Hajela for allegedly facilitating the entry of names of ineligible persons as Indian nationals in the document. In August 2025, Assam chief minister Himanta Biswa Sarma said that, once there is an opportune time, the faulty National Register of Citizens (NRC) will be corrected.

MAJOR TESTANTS

Among the four states, Kerala, Tamil Nadu, and West Bengal are ruled by opposition parties, which are vocal against the Hindu nationalist party, the BJP government in Delhi. In Assam, a BJP-led government rules. In Assam, the ruling BJP-led National Democratic Alliance (NDA) faces the Congress across all 126 seats. In Kerala, the main contest is between the ruling Left Democratic Front (LDF) and the United Democratic Front (UDF) for 140 seats. The BJP-led NDA is also in contention. The BJP plans to contest around 100 seats, while allies

Bharath Dharma Jana Sena (BDJS) and Twenty20- an Indian political party based in Kizhakkambalam, Kerala, formed in 2015, are expected to cover the remaining 40.

- » In Tamil Nadu, the ruling alliance of All India N.R. Congress (AINRC), the BJP, and the AIADMK faces the Congress-DMK-CPI combine across 234 Assembly seats.
- » In Puducherry, the ruling alliance of All India N.R. Congress (AINRC), the BJP, and the AIADMK faces the Congress-DMK-CPI combine across 30 constituencies.
- » In West Bengal, the ruling Trinamool Congress (TMC) is seeking a fourth consecutive term across the State's 294 Assembly seats, with the BJP intensifying a determined challenge.

Among the top 10 richest states (by GSDP in FY2025), two election-bound states, Tamil Nadu and West Bengal, rank second and fifth, with GSDP of Rs 31.19 lakh crore and Rs 18.15 lakh crore, respectively. Kerala stands out as a state with consistently high HDI values over the years,

attributed to its high literacy rates, robust healthcare infrastructure and relatively high income levels. Though the state of Assam, which follows the Gujarat development model, has not yet emerged as a major economic success story, it has immense geo-strategic importance to India as a gateway to East Asia.

Significantly, the other three states, ruled by the opposition parties, follow their distinctive development models to counter the neo liberal 'jobless growth model' followed by the Union government.

For example, Tamil Nadu follows the Dravidian model of governance, focused on inclusive growth for people across all walks of life, through targeted social interventions to counter caste- and gender-based negative externalities. The Kerala Model of development is based on bottom-up and state-driven development, which is about systematic State investment in education and health, resulting in a set of high material quality-of-life indicators coinciding with low per-capita incomes, both

distributed across nearly the entire population of Kerala. According to me, the four pillars of the Bengal model, introduced by the Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee, are: decentralised development, sub-regional emphasis- aiming to unite distinct ethnic and racial identities to strengthen the sub-regional identity of the divided Bengal, social inclusion and women empowerment.

SOCIO-ECONOMIC CONDITIONS

Among the four states, West Bengal houses the maximum number of people (7.5 per cent of the Indian population). Population density is also maximum in West Bengal, followed by Kerala. Interestingly, all four states have population densities higher than the Indian average. In the case of Bengal, it is over three times the Indian average, though the state has barely 2.7 per cent of the nation's geographical land.

The two southern states have higher per capita nominal GDP than the Indian average, while two states of eastern and north eastern India have lower per capita income than the national average. For Tamil Nadu, the credit-deposit ratio is strikingly high at 115 per cent compared to a very low C-D ratio for West Bengal, Assam, and Kerala. In Tamil Nadu and West Bengal, MSMEs play a very significant role. Significantly, the unemployment rate in West Bengal is the lowest (2.5), and in Kerala, the highest at 7.2.

Share of services in GSAV is very high, and Tamil Nadu's share of industry among the four states is the highest, while West Bengal has the least value among the four states.

In education and health parameters, the southern states have many impressive achievements compared to West Bengal and Assam.

Surprisingly, Kerala and Tamil Nadu have very high overall crime rates compared to West Bengal and Assam. In the case of Tamil Nadu, the total crime against women is low. So is the incidence of rape. In the other three states, figures of rapes are much higher. Rape figures are in absolute numbers, not expressed in per lakh adult women. In Assam, with a low population density compared to Kerala and West Bengal, the rape cases are alarmingly high. West Bengal has the lowest crime rate against children, followed by Tamil Nadu. In Assam and Kerala, the crime rates are higher than the national average.

Among all the models, the Dravidian model has made remarkable achievements in socio-economic sectors. Kerala model, though excelling in education and health care, has very poor crime records. Bengal has remarkably reduced the number of multidimensionally poor people, and it has also reined in crime rates. Education and health care are two areas of concern. Assam's weakest area is its failure to provide security to women and children from rapist and criminals.

TABLE 1: A FEW SOCIO-ECONOMIC PARAMETERS OF THE ELECTION BOUND STATES

PARAMETER/ STATE	WESTBENGAL	ASSAM	KERALA	TAMIL NAIDU	INDIA
Share of the State's population (%) in total population of India (2011)	7.5	2.6	2.8	6.0	100
Population density per sq Km 2011 (2001)	1,028 (903)	398 (340)	860 (819)	555 (480)	382 (324)
Nominal Per Capita GSDP in India's Nominal Per Capita GSDP (Ratio) FY 2021-22	0.8	0.7	1.5	1.6	1.0
Credit-Deposit Ratio of SCBs 2024-25 (2003)	51.6(50.0)	62.7 (61.6)	68.8 (47.9)	115.3 (89.6)	82.0 (58.7)
Number of MSMEs 2025 (%)	1800000 (7.8)	750000 (3.2)	900000 (3.9)	2174000 (9.4)	23200000 (100)
Unemployment Rate % 2023-24 (15 Years & above)	2.5	3.9	7.2	3.5	3.2
Share (%) of Agricultural/Industry/Service Sector to Total Gross State Value Added (GSAV) (Nominal), 2021-22	21.1/24.0/54.9	24.1/30.9/45	10.8/24.9/64.2	13.2/33.9/53.0	17.9/27.1/54.9 (2024-25)
Literacy rates as %age of the population aged seven and older 2024	82.6	87.0	95.3	85.5	80.9
Life Expectancy (yrs) at Birth 2019-23	72.5	68.6	75.1	73.4	70.3
Sex ratio at birth 2023 (Females per 1000 males)	931	938	971	933	917
Poverty Headcount Ratio# (HCR) 022-23 (2013-14)	8.6 (26.0)	14.5 (37.0)	0.5 (1.2)	1.4 (7.2)	11.3 (29.2)
Maternal Mortality Ratio 2021-23	104	110	30	35	88
Total Under-five Mortality rate 2023	18	33	8	13	29
Class III-V dropout rate 2024-25	2.4	3.7	0.8	2.4	2.3
Class VI-VIII dropout rate 2024-25	3.0	5.0	0.4	2.8	3.5
Class IX-XII dropout rate 2024-25	20.30	12.0	3.5	6.6	8.2

SOURCE: ECONOMIC SURVEY 2025-26, NITI AAYOG, RBI AND OTHER GOI PUBLICATIONS <https://data.worldbank.org/indicator/NY.GDP.PCAP.KD.ZG?LOCATIONS=IN> # PROPORTION OF MULTI-Dimensionally POOR IN THE POPULATION

TABLE 2: A FEW CRIME DATA 2023 OF THE ELECTION BOUND STATES



SOURCE: NATIONAL CRIME RECORDS BUREAU CRIME IN INDIA, 2023 VOL 1



Indian car-buyers and tastes are changing dramatically; most chasing size, status and screens. Carmakers are merry too, designing cars to match this psychology

AUTHOR

RAJEEV NARAYAN

There is a new desire in India, one that is being matched by a mad wheel-lust on Indian roads. The car-buyer has changed; he mutated quietly at first, then all at once. Barely a few moons ago, buying a car was a careful financial decision; families debated mileage, resale value and service costs above all else. The car itself was modest. Most were humble hatchbacks, usually white or silver, bought to serve the practical purpose of moving a family of four and their bags from A to B.

THAT ERA HAS GALLOPED INTO HISTORY

Showrooms today parade something singular yet distinct; a pageant of tall SUVs with touchscreens, panoramic sunroofs and alloy wheels that look more at home on the autobahn than on India's crowded streets. The car is no longer transport; it is symptomatic theatre. And what's being witnessed is not a change in product preference, but a psychological shift. Car-buyers are driven as much by aspiration and image as by practicality. The automobile has become an expression of success, identity and lifestyle – one that rolls along but gathers no moss. And automakers are merrily whistling in.

BIG IS BETTER

The most visible symbol of this transformation is the takeover of the SUV. Just a few years back, SUVs were niche vehicles; bulky machines driven by politicians, industrialists or working-class people who needed them for rough terrain or carrying goods. Today, SUVs dominate the market, having grown enough to command over half of passenger vehicle sales. Even cars that are essentially hatchbacks are being dressed up to look like SUVs. They sit higher, wear chunky body cladding and sport aggressive grilles. Marketing departments call them 'crossovers', but the pitch to buyers is unmistakable. Bigger is better. Because



that is what the buyer needs, everyone is told. Part of the appeal is practical. India's roads are unpredictable landscapes where potholes can appear suddenly and speed-breakers resemble masochistic challenges. A car with visibly-high ground clearance offers psychological comfort, if nothing else. Practicality alone cannot explain the craze, though. The SUV has become the new status symbol of the middle-class. A taller vehicle means prosperity, confidence and an 'arrival' in professional and personal life. In the hierarchy of modern aspiration, the hatchback suddenly feels like yesterday's car(t).

CRAZY FEATURE FEVER

Alongside the obsession with size, another phenomenon has swept through the Indian market: feature mania. A decade ago, large touchscreens, digital instrument clusters, connected-car technology and advanced driver assistance systems were limited to luxury vehicles. Today, they appear in mid-range models. They have to, if they need to sell. Sunroofs, once an indulgence, have become a magnet. Salespeople admit that buyers insist on them, even if they rarely ever open them. The feature has become shorthand for modernity and premium appeal. The new-age car-buyer expects technology everywhere – wireless smartphone connectivity, seamless voice commands, multiple cameras, ambient lighting and ever-larger displays. More often than not, the features list has become more important than the mechanical qualities of the car. Conversation has shifted from horsepower and suspension to screens and warning sensors. The automobile, in effect, is becoming another consumer electronic device, albeit one with wheels.

SOCIAL SIGNALS GALORE

Given this transformation, peer pressure plays an understated yet

powerful role. India's car purchases have always carried social meaning. The new car parked outside the house is visible, standing proof of familial and professional progress. In the age of social media, this symbolism has only intensified. Cars appear in Instagram posts, wedding processions and late-night reels celebrating 'New Car Delivery'. The automobile has become a prop in the performance of success.

TODAY'S CARS
STAND HIGH, MATCHING
UP TO BUYERS' ASPIRATIONS.
BEHIND THIS IS A
familiar story
– A NATION IN EGO-MODE,
INSISTING THAT ITS AUTOS
ARE LOUD TOO

This has subtle but significant consequences. Buyers frequently compare vehicles not just on price and reliability, but also on the mental stimuli they send to friends, relatives and colleagues. A larger car, a known brand and badge, or a panoramic sunroof, can metamorphose perceptions dramatically. The car has become less about transport and more about a signal. The Indian buyer, like car consumers everywhere, wants not just mobility... he craves recognition too.

CAR FIRMS HAPPILY OBLIGE

Automakers have been quick to read the mood. Manufacturers that once focused heavily on compact hatchbacks are launching SUVs in every imaginable size and price bracket. From entry-level micro-SUVs to premium flagship models, the segment has exploded with options.



Design language has also changed. Cars now look more muscular and dramatic – sculpted body panels, oversized grilles and LED lighting signatures designed to stand out in traffic. Inside the cabin, screens dominate dashboards that once held simple analogue dials. Connectivity features are marketed as aggressively as engines. In effect, the Indian automobile industry has become part-psychologist and part-fashion designer, interpreting the evolving desires of the consumer and translating them into metal, glass and software. The shift is so dramatic that even once conservative manufacturers are reinventing themselves to remain relevant and appear cool.

MATURE, BUT WANNABE

What does this transformation mean for India's automotive future? It signals a market that is rapidly maturing. As incomes rise and credit becomes more accessible, buyers want to be seen moving up the value chain. The car is thus no longer just a tool for transport; it is a lifestyle statement. This trend sparks risks too. Larger vehicles consume more space on crowded roads. Feature-heavy cars are more expensive, pushing entry-level buyers out of the market. And the increasing complexity of vehicles raises questions about long-term reliability and ownership costs. Yet, the shift is not one that can be dismissed away as vanity. Aspiration is a powerful engine of economic growth. The desire for better, bigger and more sophisticated products is pushing industries to innovate and compete. The auto market is only reflecting a broader societal transformation: from cautious frugality to brash ambition. Cars are bigger, screens brighter and aspirations louder. But beneath it all is a familiar story. A nation in ego-mode, resolute that its vehicles should echo the decibel of its wannabe dreams.



SIMULATING A CHANGING PLANET



As climate risks intensify, understanding how models work becomes crucial to interpreting projections, policy choices, and environmental consequences

AUTHOR

KRISHNA GUPTA

There can be Atmosphere GCMs, Ocean GCMs, and a combination of the two. While Atmosphere GCMs consist of hundreds of equations on temperature, winds, humidity, water, and clouds, these are then put together in a computer program, giving us future projections. As discussed above, the data is arranged in a three-dimensional grid spacing of the Earth, which includes the horizontal and vertical aspects of the atmosphere. The equations behind the computer model are based on fundamental laws of physics in thermodynamics and fluid dynamics for an ideal gas. While many of the horizontal atmospheric processes are easily handled by the grid, many vertical processes, which have a limited geographical spread, need to be parameterised. To elaborate, a grid is typically 100 km by 100 km, but many processes, such as cloud formation or convection, occur on a much smaller scale or too quickly. To model these, a simple guide or an algorithm is used to approximate the process at a sub-grid level; this is known as parameterisation.

Ocean GCMs model the processes in the oceans at the surface and sub-surface levels. As in Atmosphere GCMs, the horizontal aspects are much larger than the vertical aspects. Ocean GCMs have to consider a more complex topography, including continents, ocean floors, straits, and basins. Further, the ideal gas laws used in Atmosphere GCMs have to be modified, and other laws of thermodynamics and fluid dynamics have to be invoked in Ocean GCMs. Here too, parameterisation of many important processes, which happen on a small scale (such as turbulent mixing of waters on the surface, mixing with tidal waters, or eddies), has to be done. Atmosphere and Ocean GCMs are coupled to give AOGCMs, where the exchange of heat, salinity, and momentum is integrated to provide a comprehensive model. These models help us understand how a change in surface ocean temperature affects winds and leads to hurricanes and cyclones. Similarly, they help us analyse how a change in atmospheric temperature affects ocean currents. For example, AOGCMs help us simulate phenomena such as the El Niño–Southern Oscillation, which includes the El Niño and La Niña currents and affects weather and rainfall across the world.

EARTH SYSTEM MODELS

When biogeochemical aspects, such as the carbon cycle and ice sheets, are added to AOGCMs, we get Earth System Models (ESMs). All ESMs are therefore GCMs, but not all GCMs are ESMs. With the carbon cycle included, ESMs can analyse the exchange of carbon dioxide between land, air, and oceans, which includes processes such as photosynthesis, respiration, and other ecosystem aspects such as deforestation, mangroves, plant and animal

life, etc. ESMs are therefore more comprehensive and can be used to answer various ecological questions, such as the impact of climate change on mangroves or plankton.

REGIONAL CLIMATE MODELS

Since the geographical scale of GCMs and ESMs can be rather large, it is difficult to study climate change and its impact at a regional level. For this, regional climate models have often been suggested. Such regional models define boundary conditions, which are often taken from global climate models. Boundary conditions are simply the values of variables such as temperature, wind, and pressure at the boundary of the region. Regional models can be useful because they incorporate local conditions into the model, such as topography, which can provide results with higher resolution and greater detail. The drawback of regional climate models is that the boundary conditions are derived from global models and are therefore biased, and they cannot provide feedback loops from local and regional climates to the global climate.

THE COUPLED MODEL INTERCOMPARISON PROJECT

Another important milestone in climate modelling was the establishment of CMIP by the World Climate Research Programme (WCRP) in 1995. The WCRP was founded in 1980 under the World Meteorological Organisation in Geneva and today underpins much of the scientific research under the United Nations Framework

CLIMATE MODELS ARE NOT JUST PREDICTIVE TOOLS—THEY ARE FRAMEWORKS TO UNDERSTAND HOW EARTH'S SYSTEMS RESPOND TO HUMAN ACTIONS

Convention on Climate Change (UNFCCC). CMIP was essentially a project to compare the multitude of GCMs and ESMs being developed, along with the variety of results being produced. It began as a small initiative to run standard experiments, such as model behaviour with a 1 per cent increase in carbon dioxide. The more recent CMIP5 and CMIP6 are far more sophisticated and have incorporated past climate data to provide future climate projections. CMIP6 also includes various socioeconomic conditions to suggest different pathways of global greenhouse gas emissions and their consequences.

CONCLUSION

We have discussed the evolution and hierarchy of various climate models above. Climate models are a valuable tool for studying past climates and providing projections for the next century. All climate models are underpinned by fundamental laws of physics and offer reasonably accurate projections. These projections also provide guidance for the social and economic policies we should adopt. All models point to the urgent need to reduce greenhouse gas emissions, mitigate their effects, and prepare to adapt to the adverse impacts of climate change that we are already witnessing.

Legacy Lost in Uniform?

Delhi Police, once rooted in the legendary integrity of the Kotwal system, now faces growing public distrust amid allegations of corruption and misconduct



AUTHOR



INDER VASHISTH

The Delhi Police may not enjoy a good image today. However, the force has a glorious history. There was a time when Delhi's Kotwal was often cited as an example of honesty. The Delhi Police has prominently mentioned stories of the Kotwal's integrity in its history, yet today, no police officer can be compared to that standard. The situation has deteriorated to such an extent that people are appalled by the corruption within the police force. Policemen themselves are found involved in serious crimes like extortion, robbery, and collusion with criminals. Corruption is rampant within the force.

Corruption is not merely about accepting bribes. If a police officer fails to perform his or her duties honestly, fails to provide individuals with their rightful

protections, refuses to register a criminal case, files a false case, implicates or arrests an innocent person, or protects subordinates who collude with criminals, it is not just corruption but a serious crime. The misuse of authority by IPS officers for personal gain, squandering public funds, and using government vehicles for family purposes also constitute corruption.

The origins of the Delhi Police system are believed to date back approximately 800 years. At that time, the Kotwal (City Police Chief) was responsible for maintaining security and law and order in Delhi. Gangadhar, the grandfather of India's first Prime Minister, Pandit Jawaharlal Nehru, was the last Kotwal of Delhi. The Delhi Police has come a long way from that era to becoming one of the most well-resourced police forces in the country.

Delhi's first Kotwal (Police Chief) was Malikul Umara Faqrudin. He became Kotwal in 1237 AD at the age of 40. In addition to his role as Kotwal, he was also appointed Naib-e-Gibt (in the absence of the Regent). Due to his integrity, he held this position for a long time during the reigns of three Sultans.

On one occasion, when some Turkish nobles approached him to secure the withdrawal of Balban's order confiscating their estates, the Kotwal is recorded to have said, "My words will carry no weight if I accept any bribe from you."

The Kotwal's police headquarters was located in Qila Rai Pithora, present-day Mehrauli.



TODAY, WITH OVER 80,000 PERSONNEL AND 225 POLICE STATIONS, DELHI POLICE IS AMONG THE world's largest METROPOLITAN FORCES. YET CONTINUES TO FACE CHALLENGES OF TRUST AND ACCOUNTABILITY

History also records the name of Kotwal Malik Ala-ul-Mulk, who was appointed by Sultan Alauddin Khilji in 1297 AD. Sultan Khilji once remarked about him, "I am appointing him as Kotwal, even though he is worthy of the position of Wazir (Prime Minister)." It is also mentioned that while leaving for war, Sultan Khilji handed over the keys of the city to Kotwal Malik, instructing him to give them to the victor and serve him with the same loyalty.

When Mughal Emperor Shah Jahan made Delhi his capital in 1648, Ghazanfar Khan was appointed the first Kotwal of the new city of Shahjahanabad. He was later also appointed Mir-e-Atish (Chief of Artillery).

After the 1857 Revolt, the British captured Delhi, and the Kotwal system came to an end. Pandit Gangadhar Nehru, the grandfather of Pandit Jawaharlal Nehru and father of Motilal Nehru, was the Kotwal of Delhi during the reign of the last Mughal emperor, Bahadur Shah Zafar.

According to the Ain-i-Akbari, the Kotwal was required to be present during court proceedings. He received daily updates on the city's activities through chowkidars (watchmen) and informants. The British reorganised the police in 1857. At that time, Delhi was part of Punjab. Even after becoming the capital in 1912, policing in Delhi continued under the Punjab Police. The first Chief Commissioner of Delhi was appointed and given powers equivalent to the Inspector General of Police (IG), with headquarters in Ambala.

According to the 1912 Gazette, the Delhi Police was controlled by a DIG-rank officer. The force was commanded by a Superintendent (SP) and a Deputy SP. At that time, there were two inspectors, 27 sub-inspectors, 110 head constables, 985 constables, and 28 cavalrymen in the city. Rural areas had two inspectors, with headquarters in Sonapat and Ballabgarh. Ten police stations came under three tehsils—Sonapat, Delhi, and

Ballabgarh.

In 1861, the British established five police stations in Delhi: Sabzi Mandi, Kotwali, Sadar Bazaar, Mehrauli, and Mundka (now Nangloi). Police barracks were located in Civil Lines.

The historic Kotwali police station building was later handed over to Gurudwara Sis Ganj Sahib. The Nangloi police station, established in 1861 for rural areas, was known as the Mundka police station until 1872.

The Delhi Police was reorganised in 1946, and the number of personnel was doubled. In 1948, D.W. Mehra was appointed as the first Inspector General of Police in Delhi. Since his appointment was made on February 16, the date is celebrated as Delhi Police Foundation Day. The Police Commissioner system was implemented in Delhi on July 1, 1978.

On October 31, 2019, the Delhi Police Headquarters shifted to its newly constructed 17-storey building on Jai Singh Marg, near Parliament House in New Delhi. Earlier, the headquarters operated from ITO and Kashmiri Gate. Delhi currently has 225 police stations and a police force of approximately 80,000 personnel.

Today, the Delhi Police is perhaps the largest metropolitan police force in the world, larger than those of London, Paris, New York and Tokyo.

The police have a glorious history. Honest officers must draw inspiration from it and strive to restore the force's credibility. Only then can its image truly be revived.

Views expressed are personal

Of Wounds and Inheritance

Manish Gaekwad's Nautch Boy is a piercing memoir of queerness, stigma, violence, inheritance and a son's enduring bond with his mother

AUTHOR



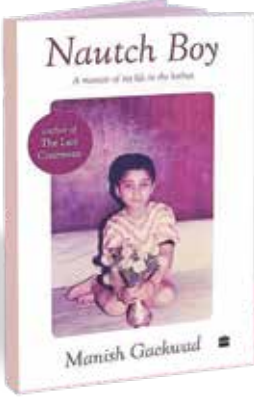
YAUVANIKA CHOPRA

"My mother entertained the thought of killing me. A few hours before I was born. In the hierarchy of noble thoughts, I ranked second in priority. Her own life claimed the top spot—and with good reason: She had to survive before any of this. Whether my story or even hers, was possible."

This is the first line of Manish Gaekwad's searing memoir *Nautch Boy*, dedicated to the mother whose dance shaped his dreams and titled after one of the many epithets accorded to him over the course of his extraordinary life. The introduction goes on to explain why his mother Rekha had thought of letting him go. Daughters born to tawaifs like her could carry on the community trade, but sons were not as useful. The unborn baby's illegitimate father Rehmat Khan had refused to lend his name or presence to the child. "Was there a more cursed life than to be born an orphan? She knew perfectly well how difficult it would be for me. She had seen a worse fate—as a child, she had been used to pay off a debt to a Bedia family, dressed as a child bride, raped by her husband and then sold to a kotha. When a family offered no guarantees, could one be better off without it?"

Mother and Son both survived. Father suggested at one point that the boy should be named Aurangzeb, but refused still to grant his surname. Rekha Bai - also known as Rehana - named him Manish instead. She had been an extra during the filming of the song *Om Shanti Om*, sitting in the audience while Rishi Kapoor danced under pink disco lights with his character name M-O-N-T-Y lit up behind him. Monty became Manish's daak naam pet name. His surname was made Gaikwad after the principal at a boarding school in Darjeeling misheard his mother's mumbled answer to who her son's father was. Manish changed the spelling to Gaekwad later, with an 'e' instead of 'i', to match the spelling of Shivaji Rao Gaekwad "Rajinikanth."

"Naazuk" was a word used to describe the author by both his mother and the other young men of his age: a lesser pejorative from the parent, and deliberately cruel from the peers. Sports held little appeal, and books were preferred companions for a boy living away from home who knew that he was queer before he was familiar with the vocabulary of this difference or had the confidence to articulate it in ownership.



There were other insults too, alongside thinly veiled fetishisation, as tends to happen for those who do not conform. In his early experiments with performing on stage for Founder's Day (partly motivated by the promise of extra food for all those who contributed), Manish danced to *Sun Sahiba Sun* and a hostile crowd of students. "An English teacher named Suzanna had warned me backstage before my performance. Boys don't do these things, she had said in a sharp, disciplinary tone. That must have shaken my confidence. I did not have the time to react as she announced

my name to perform. She was a teacher I idolised for her larger-than-life persona. She was always so immaculately dressed in bright pink and yellow minis, wore polished patent leather high heels, chunky gold jewellery, had the reddest lipstick possible that would contrast with skin as fair as hers, and matched with a perfectly coiffured bouffant—really a modern English version of a tawaif, if there was such a thing."

A keen observer of life around him - at the Kolkata kotha and the Darjeeling boarding school - Manish's sense of the world also began to be shaped by the books he read. Pivoting to theatre after the cold reception received by his filmy dances, he decided to adapt *Cinderella* into a gender-swapped play called *Cinderarchie* with him in the lead role (after nobody else accepted the part) and a girl named Manisha as Princess Charming, who proposes to him on stage. "I froze. I forgot my line. One word. I was supposed to say yes... The curtain dropped on my promising career on stage. I stopped putting up my name for quizzes, extempores, elocutions and poetry recitals... I grew into even more of an introvert."

Even when he was no longer looking for a spotlight, it would be thrust upon him. In literature class, a speech by Cassius

in *Julius Caesar* gave the boys ammunition for another mean nickname: "But, woe the while, our fathers' minds are dead / And we are governed with our mothers' spirits / Our yoke and suzerance show us womanish." "Wo-Manish". He did not react to the mocking laughter. Instead, he acknowledged the significance of those lines to his own life.

Like the protagonist in Anton Chekhov's *The Bet*, Manish read as widely as he could and began writing soon after: a daily journal, translations of the ghazal lyrics practiced by the tawaifs, news features, essays, profiles of his fascinating beautiful complex tawaif mother, movie scripts, a debut novel *Lean Days*, a critically-acclaimed biography *The Last Courtesan: Writing My Mother's Memoir, and Nautch Boy*.

Violence is a running theme throughout this memoir. The shadows of what it leaves behind colour the experiences of both Mother and Son as they grow up and grow old. Some of it is political - the Bowbazar bomb blasts in 1993, which wiped out most kothas; much of it is societal - stigma, crude

conflations, financial hardship. There is a seventeen-year gap in the book after which the narrative resumes in 2019.

Many of the early loops of the story - and the intertwined lives of Rekha and Manish - find poetic rhythms of settling. The Son becomes Mother to the woman who had birthed him. He records her voice and writes her story.

"She has nothing to hide, protect or hold sacred. She will not doubt leave out intimate details, she will not have proof to back her claims, she will not have a chronology, an almanack of records or paperwork, not even photographs (actually, she does have a few)." One photograph that survives is of her ill-fated sister, Hasina—on the cover of the 1983 Merchant-Ivory documentary *The Courtesans of Bombay*. The other sisters Laccha, Rajjo, and Laxmi had sad fates as well, but with the added burden-blessing of obscurity. "Rekha"

itself is fate, in one sense—when a doctor asks what her name means, she stretches out her hand to show him the lines on her palm. Slender threads of destiny braid together a family whose maternal ancestral surname had possibly been the nomadic Tamaich. To Manish, the word "savarna" was initially associated with dressing up ("sajna-savarna"), and only later took on the personal and political classification of Denotified Tribal identity. His own self was shaped less by these notions, more by his family, most by his mother.

Love is the other current in this book — it begins, remains, destroys — and crescendoes as the Mother remembers the tender-fierce lullaby written by Sahir Ludhianvi for the film *Trishul* which she used to sing to the Son when he was in her womb: "Tera koi bhi nahin mere siwa / Mera koi bhi nahin tere siwa / Tu mere saath rahega, Munne." Rekha saw herself in Waheeda Rehman's character. Echoes would have resonated against the story of Sahir Ludhianvi's own mother Sardar Begum. The story is eternal. Music and memory coalesce for Mother and Son in this swan song ode to a life vanishing and a legacy preserved.

IN THIS UNSPARING AND TENDER MEMOIR, MANISH Gaekwad TRACES A LIFE SHAPED BY THE TAWAIF WORLD, SOCIAL CRUELTY AND LOVE



AUTHOR



VINOD KUMAR

The France Beyond Paris

Travellers often confine their French itineraries to Paris, overlooking Colmar in Alsace, a gateway to vineyards and charming medieval villages

Most people, when they think of France, instinctively think of Paris. The Eiffel Tower at dusk, the Louvre's glass pyramid, cafés lining the boulevards where writers once scribbled in notebooks. Paris has long dominated the imagination of travellers. Yet France is far larger and more varied than its capital, and some of its most memorable corners lie quietly beyond the famous avenues of the city. I discovered this truth in Colmar, a small town in the Alsace region near the German border, where half-timbered houses lean toward narrow canals and time appears to slow down just enough for a traveller to notice the details that big cities often blur.

My journey to Colmar began, predictably enough, in Paris. After a night in the capital, I boarded a morning train from Gare de l'Est that sped eastward through the French countryside. In less than three hours the train had crossed fields, vineyards and sleepy villages before arriving in a place that felt entirely different from Parisian grandeur. Colmar station was modest and quiet. Outside, the air carried the faint scent of bakeries and autumn leaves. Within minutes of walking into the old town, I realised I had stepped into a landscape that seemed lifted from a storybook. Wooden houses painted in pastel shades—pistachio green, soft pink, faded yellow—stood shoulder to shoulder along cobbled streets.

Colmar's historic centre is compact enough to explore on foot, and wandering without a map quickly became my favourite way of discovering it. One afternoon I found myself beside a canal in a neighbourhood known as Petite Venise, or "Little Venice". Boats drifted slowly through the water while geraniums spilled from wooden balconies above. A local man leaning against the railing struck up a conversation when he noticed I was taking photographs. He told me he had lived in Colmar all his life and had never felt the urge to move elsewhere. "People think Paris is France," he said with a smile, "but Paris is only one chapter." His remark stayed with me through the rest of the journey.

Colmar itself is charming, but its greatest strength is that it serves as a perfect base to explore the surrounding Alsace region. The countryside here unfolds in gentle slopes covered with vineyards that have produced wine for centuries. The famous Alsace Wine Route winds through villages whose names—Riquewihr, Eguisheim, Kaysersberg—sound almost musical when spoken aloud. Renting a small car allowed me to wander freely between these places, though distances



170 km

Length of the Alsace Wine Route, connecting vineyards and picturesque villages across the region



100+ VINEYARDS

Number of wine-producing villages connected along the Alsace Wine Route, famous for Riesling, Gewürztraminer and Pinot Gris



are short enough that even a bus or bicycle could connect them.

The first village I visited was Eguisheim, a circular medieval settlement just a few kilometres from Colmar. Its streets spiral around a central square like the rings of a tree. Early in the morning the town was almost silent except for the sound of shutters opening and a baker placing fresh loaves in the display window. I bought a warm croissant and sat on a stone bench as a group of cyclists rode past, their wheels echoing softly on the cobbles. Moments like these are easy to overlook in travel writing, but they are often what linger longest in memory.

Another afternoon took me to Riquewihr, often described as one of the most beautiful villages in France. Tourism has certainly discovered it, but arriving late in the day offered a different experience. As evening approached, day-trippers began leaving and the village slowly returned to its quieter rhythm. A wine shop owner invited me to taste a glass of Riesling produced from vines that had grown in the surrounding hills for generations. We spoke about travel, about India, and

inevitably about the news that flickered from a small television behind the counter. The world's troubles felt distant here, yet they were never entirely absent. Even in a medieval village, people remained connected to events unfolding far beyond the vineyards.

Back in Colmar, evenings developed their own gentle routine. The old town becomes particularly magical after sunset when the façades of historic buildings are illuminated with soft golden light. Restaurants place small tables along the canals and narrow streets. One evening I ordered tarte flambée, a traditional Alsatian dish resembling a thin pizza topped with cream, onions and bacon. At the neighbouring table sat an elderly couple who had travelled from Strasbourg for a short holiday. They were curious about my visit and surprised to learn that I had chosen Colmar instead of Paris. "You have chosen well," the woman said kindly. "Paris is beautiful, but Alsace is where you understand how people really live."

Exploring the region revealed how deeply history has shaped Alsace. For centuries the territory shifted between

France and Germany, and traces of both cultures remain visible today. Street names, architecture and even cuisine reflect this blend. In Colmar's markets, for instance, one finds French pastries beside German-style sausages. Churches display Gothic spires while nearby buildings carry the wooden frames typical of German towns. This mixture gives the region a character unlike anywhere else in France.

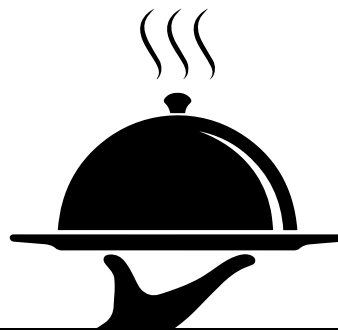
One particularly memorable day trip led me to Kaysersberg, a village framed by vineyards and overlooked by the ruins of a medieval castle. Walking through its streets felt almost like stepping into another century. A small bridge crosses a river that flows beneath rows of colourful houses, and from the castle hill the entire valley spreads out in quiet beauty.

Sitting there for a while, watching clouds drift slowly over the Vosges Mountains, I understood why travellers often describe Alsace as peaceful. The landscape invites a kind of reflection that larger cities rarely allow.

What makes Colmar special, however, is not simply its beauty but the rhythm of life that unfolds there. Mornings begin with cafés serving strong coffee and freshly baked pastries. By midday the market squares fill with locals buying vegetables, cheese and bread. In the afternoon tourists wander through museums or take boat rides along the canals, while residents continue their routines with an ease that suggests they have mastered the art of living well. It is a town that encourages travellers to slow down and observe rather than rush from attraction to attraction.

On my final evening in Colmar I returned once more to the canal in Petite Venise. The same pastel houses reflected in the water, their colours softened by twilight. A group of children laughed as they fed ducks near the bridge. Somewhere nearby a church bell rang the hour. It struck me then that travel often reveals places that exist quietly outside the narratives we usually hear. France, in popular imagination, may begin and end with Paris. Yet towns like Colmar remind us that the soul of a country often resides in its smaller corners—in villages, vineyards and streets where daily life unfolds without spectacle.

As the train carried me away the next morning, the vineyards and timbered houses gradually faded from view. But the memory of Colmar lingered: a gentle town in Alsace that quietly redefines what it means to discover France.



GASTRONOMY

PRAWN AGLIO E OLIO



INGREDIENTS

- » Spaghetti — 250 g
- » Prawns (peeled and deveined) — 200 g
- » Garlic (thinly sliced) — 4–5 cloves
- » Extra virgin olive oil — 4 tbsp
- » Red chilli flakes — 1 tsp
- » Fresh parsley (finely chopped) — 1 tbsp
- » Lemon zest — from ½ lemon (optional)
- » Salt — to taste
- » Freshly ground black pepper — to taste
- » Reserved pasta water — 2 tbsp
- » Lemon wedges — for serving
- » Parmesan cheese (optional) — 2 tbsp, grated

DIRECTIONS

Bring a large pot of salted water to a boil and cook the spaghetti according to package instructions until al dente. The pasta should be tender but still slightly firm when bitten. Before draining, reserve a small cup of the pasta cooking water. This starchy liquid will help the sauce bind smoothly with the pasta. Drain the spaghetti and keep it aside while you prepare the prawns. In a wide skillet, heat the olive oil over medium heat. Add the sliced garlic and cook gently until it turns lightly golden and fragrant. Stir continuously and keep the flame moderate so the garlic does not burn. Once the garlic releases its aroma, add the chilli flakes and let them briefly infuse the oil. Add the prawns to the pan and season lightly with salt and freshly ground black pepper. Cook them for about two to three minutes, turning them once, until they become pink and opaque. Avoid overcooking, as prawns can quickly turn rubbery. As soon as they are done, reduce the heat. Add the cooked spaghetti directly to the skillet and toss it well so that the garlic-infused oil coats the strands evenly. Pour in a couple of tablespoons of the reserved pasta water and mix gently. The starch from the water helps emulsify the oil, giving the pasta a light glossy coating rather than leaving it oily. Finally, add the lemon zest and chopped parsley, then toss the prawns back into the pasta and mix everything together briefly. Taste and adjust seasoning if required. Serve immediately with lemon wedges on the side and, if desired, a light sprinkle of grated Parmesan. The dish should taste simple yet vibrant, with the sweetness of prawns balanced by garlic, chilli and fragrant olive oil.



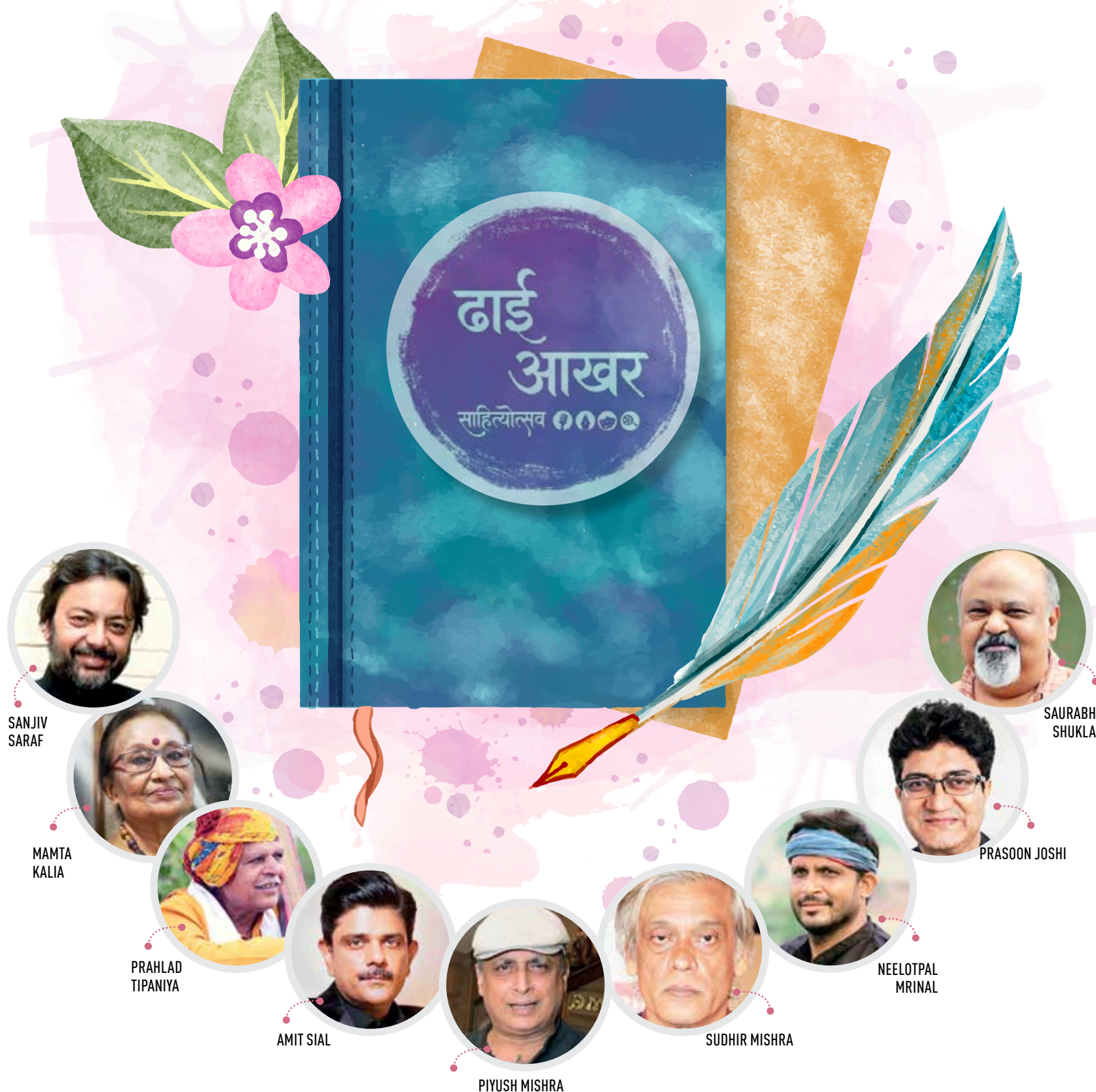
TIP

Always cook prawns briefly over medium heat; overcooking makes them rubbery and dulls their natural sweetness.



Heritage in Conversation

From 27 to 29 March, Hindi Bhavan will host a literary and cultural gathering that moves from poetry and dialogue to cinema, music and folk theatre



From 27 to 29 March 2026, Hindi Bhavan will host Dhai Aakh Sahityotsav, a two-and-a-half-day literary and cultural gathering that brings together some of the most distinguished voices in contemporary Hindi literature, arts and performance. Conceived as a confluence of poetry, dialogue, music, cinema and theatre, the festival offers not simply a sequence of sessions, but an immersive passage through the many living textures of Indian expressive tradition. Its guiding theme, *Virasat se Bhavishy tak* ("From Heritage to the Future"), sets the tonal register at once: rooted, yet restless.

The festival opens on 27 March with the session *Agagaz*, being inaugurated by Gajendra Singh Shekhawat, Union Culture and Tourism Minister, and by setting a contemplative yet vibrant note with lyricist and writer Prasoona Joshi in conversation with Rajeev Ranjan. The evening is graced by the celebrated folk artist Prahlad Tipaniya, whose rendition of Kabir weaves together devotion, dissent and artistry in a manner wholly characteristic of the festival's own spirit.

The second day, 28 March, unfolds as a rich literary tapestry. Its most anticipated session, *Bargad ki Chhaon Mein*, brings together four towering figures of Hindi poetry, many of them being Sahitya Akademi Awardees: Ashok Vajpeyi, Nandkishore Acharya, Arun Kamal, Uday Prakash and Rameshwar Rai, in an unhurried conversation that anchors the festival in the depth and plurality of poetic tradition. The afternoon poetry session 'K' se *Kavita* extends this spirit further, featuring poets like Babushah Kohli, Dipak Jaiswal, Satendra Shukla, and Poet-Administrators, Ashutosh Agnihotri and Nishant Jain. A session of particular significance, *Aadhi Duniya... Poora Fasana* gathers prominent women writers: Mamta

Kalia, Anamika, Nirmala Putul, Sudha Singh and Garima Srivastava, offering sustained reflection on gendered experience, literary form and social reality. The day widens to embrace other art forms: cinema finds representation in *Bioscope: Cinema ki Kahani*, with filmmaker Sudhir Mishra and Gaurav Dwivedi, while theatre takes the stage in *Rang-Abhinay-Rang* with Actor, Writer, and Director, Saurabh Shukla, Chitaranjan Tripathi, Director of NSD, and Rahul Mittra, Producer of films like *Saheb Biwi Aur Gangster*, *Sarkar 3*. The session, *Do-Aab: Ek Yatra*, features Sanjeev Saraf, the founder of *Jashn-e-Rekhta*, in a reflective journey through the confluences of language,

memory and lived experience. The evening closes with the evocative storytelling tradition of *Dastangoi* in *Dastan-e-Sahir*, performed by Himanshu Vajpeyi and Pragya Sharma.

The final day, 29 March, turns its attention toward media, evolving language and the poetics of the contemporary. *Sahityik Patrakarita* and *Chautha Khamba* explore the intersections of literature and journalism, with participants including Om Thanvi, Sanjay Sahay,

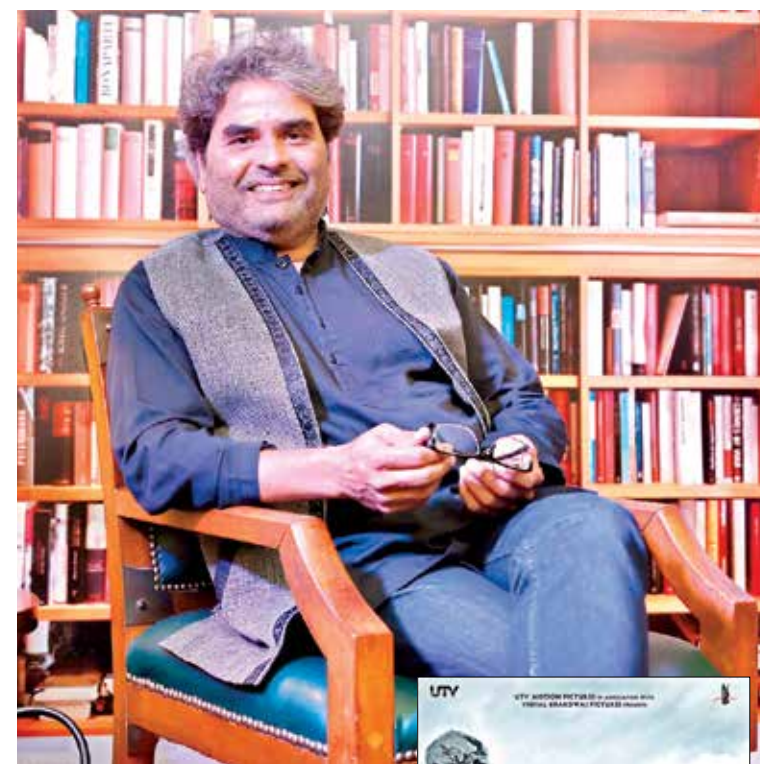
Prem Janmejay, Vyomesh Shukla, Ashish Pande, Rajeev Ranjan and Sanket Upadhyay. *Nayi Zabaan Naye Kisse* turns to emerging voices and shifting idioms, featuring Divyaprakash Dube, Neelotpal Mrinal, Praveen Kumar and Shailesh Bharatwasi. The lyrical strand continues in *Shayari ke Dhanak Rang* with Kamna Prasad and Minu Bakshi.

The closing evening is designed to linger. *Nazm aur Nagme* brings together Piyush Mishra, Amit Sial and Gaurav Dwivedi in a musical and poetic celebration, and Sudhanshu Trivedi, Member of Parliament, speaks on Hindi in the global context, after which the festival concludes with a staging of Bhikari Thakur's folk theatre classic *Bidesiya*, directed by Sanjay Upadhyay and presented by Nirmaan Kala Manch, Patna. It is a fitting close: classical in form, immediate in feeling, and alive in the present moment.

At its heart, Dhai Aakh understands language not merely as a vehicle of communication, but as a living cultural force, one that binds poetry to politics, devotion to dissent, and memory to becoming. The festival's carefully held arc, from classical invocation through contemporary discourse to folk theatre, ensures an experience that is at once intellectually serious and humanly warm. Open to all who love literature, art and thoughtful exchange, Dhai Aakh 2026 invites its audiences into a space where words are not merely read or heard, but deeply felt.

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THE FUTURE

'Cinema of heart & sensibility taking a beating in theatres'



Vishal Bhardwaj stated that good cinema is going through a deep struggle

BEDIKA

Good cinema is going through a deep struggle, said Vishal Bhardwaj. This was the case in the pre-OTT era and even now, with filmmakers taking their projects to streaming platforms and being told the film should be released in theatres first.

The casualty of this is 'cinema of the heart and sensibility', added the 'O' Romeo' director. 20 years ago, it would be easy to raise money for films such as his own 'Haider', Vikramaditya Motwane's 'Udaan' and Anurag Kashyap's 'Gangs of Wasseypur' that were released in theatres and celebrated by discerning audiences. Not anymore.

"Now you won't be able to raise money for them. Now there is a straight demarcation: 'This is the subject, take it to OTT' and OTT people say, 'No, we don't want it. Release it in theatres first, then we will take it here.' Good films are getting beaten in the process," Bhardwaj told PTI.

What is needed is a 'revolutionary step' and we don't know when that will happen and whether it will be through a film or a new medium, he said. The current theatrical landscape, Bhardwaj went on to explain, is difficult for filmmakers, with his contemporaries and directors he admires now telling their stories on streaming platforms.

"We are in a very strange and difficult phase of filmmaking. I think it's global... The films to be made for theatres have taken a totally new turn," Bhardwaj said.

Referring to his contemporaries - Anurag, Dibakar (Banerjee), Shriram (Raghavan), Vikramaditya and Imtiaz (Ali) - he said most are working for OTT. And even if they do make films for theatres, it doesn't always work.

"It's so sad. I don't remember Vikram's last film in theatres. I am Vikram's fan. I am Dibakar's great fan, they make great cinema," Bhardwaj added.

According to the director, theatrical movies faced a challenge in the past with the advent of satellite television. Then, the gap between a film's release in theatres and its arrival on TV would be five to six months. Today, a film is released in theatres and is on some OTT platform eight weeks later.

"If you want to make films for theatres, you have to look at yourself from a new perspective. By doing all that, how do you still keep yourself alive in that film is a challenge. In between, OTT platforms were making origi-

What is needed is a 'revolutionary step' and we don't know when that will happen and whether it will be through a film or a new medium, he said

nals, but that's also now less... Good cinema is going through a deep struggle, which is always the case anyway," the filmmaker said.

He added, "To make people go that 'I want to see it now, I don't want to wait for eight weeks', to create that lure, you have to do all kinds of things. What is happening is, the ones who are getting defeated are the cinema of the heart, cinema of the sensibilities," he said.

The days following the release of his 2003 film 'Maqbool', starring Irrfan, Pankaj Kapur, Tabu and Piyush Mishra, were great for directors, Bhardwaj said.

"Around 2004-2005 and before the pandemic, it was the golden period. You could make anything. You could release anything; people used to come to theatres for films like 'Haider'. 'Gangs of Wasseypur' becomes a cult... 'Khosla Ka Ghosla', 'Oye Lucky Lucky Oye' and 'Udaan', he said.

The filmmaker, who most recently released Shahid Kapoor-Triptii Dimristarrer 'O' Romeo, said the advent of OTT, rising ticket prices and the shortening gap between the theatrical window and the films' arrival and other such factors have led to the dip in theatrical business.

"I was in Delhi and a few of my friends were going to watch my film. So, they said, 'Give us Rs 6,000, we are going to watch your film.' There were three. I said, 'Why 6,000?' They said, 'You don't know? The ticket price is Rs 1,900 rupees per seat in that hall. Everyone must have their reasons, the theatres and the infrastructure of the theatres, the taxes or whatever. People say they will watch it on OTT. But there is so much content available on OTT, not just Indian, but globally, there is so much available. We need a revolutionary step and we don't know when that will happen and whether it will be through a film or a new medium?"

AGENCIES

